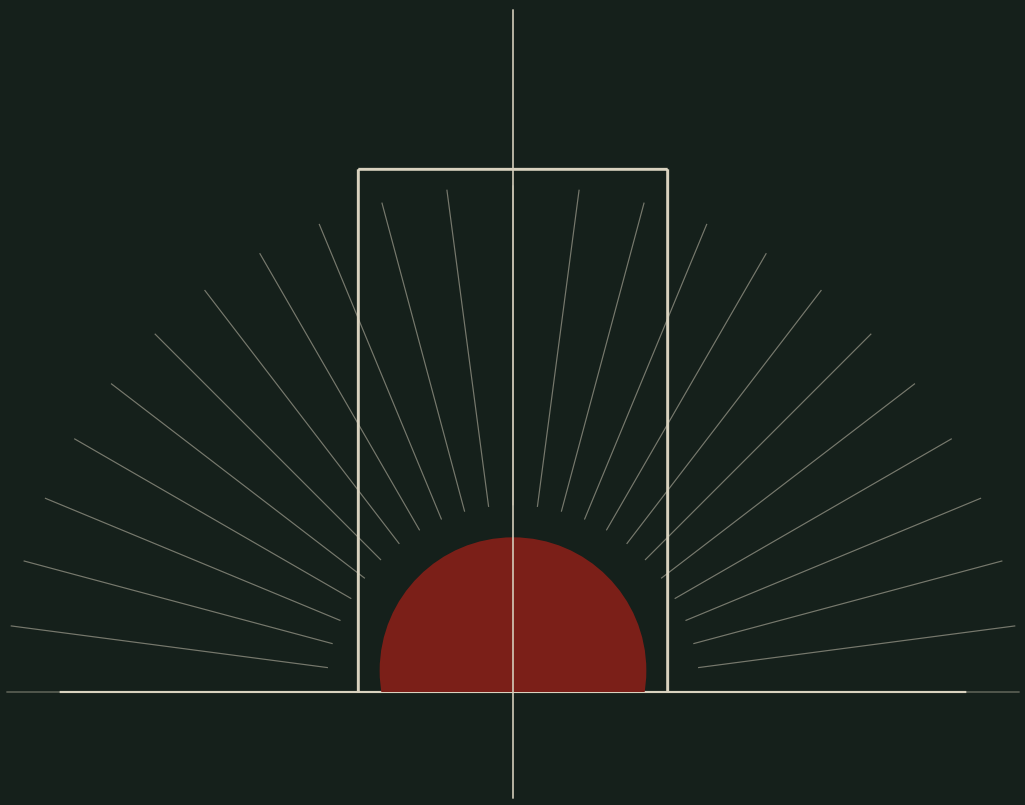


Lycanthropology

Ban, Rite, and Hierophantic Realism in the Cinema of Robert Eggers

A doctoral dissertation
October 2026

Abstract

This dissertation advances a systematic mytho-philosophical reading of the four completed feature films of Robert Eggers—*The Witch: A New-England Folktale* (2015), *The Lighthouse* (2019), *The Northman* (2022), and *Nosferatu* (2024)—and proposes an original theoretical synthesis, lycanthropology, to account for their coherence as a single intellectual project. Against the critical commonplaces that assimilate Eggers either to the marketing category of "elevated horror" or to an antiquarian cinema of period reconstruction, it argues that his signature fidelity to the material, linguistic, and photochemical textures of the past is liturgical rather than documentary in function. The resulting aesthetic regime, here termed hierophantic realism, deploys archival exactitude as a prosthesis for the faith that, as Alejo Carpentier observed, the marvelous presupposes. Each film is set at a threshold of disenchantment: the conversion-era North Atlantic on the eve of Christian kingship; Calvinist New England at the inception of the Great Migration; the Biedermeier interval between Enlightenment medicine and Romantic *Naturphilosophie*; and the bureaucratized maritime frontier of the 1890s. Read in diegetic rather than production chronology, the corpus composes a genealogy of Western *Entzauberung* narrated from the side of its casualties.

Across this genealogy a single structure recurs. A subject constituted by a ban—exile, outlawry, enslavement, quarantine—undergoes an initiation without return: a rite of passage, in the sense of Arnold van Gennep and Victor Turner, whose liminal phase is lived "between two deaths" and whose phase of reaggregation is displaced from the social order into the numinous. The passage is conducted by an anomalous mediator (goat, gull, raven, wolf, rat) and administered by a feminine figure designated the threshold-sovereign: she who, in a transposition of Carl Schmitt from politics to ontology, decides on the exception between orders of being. Its consummation is a terminal ecstasy in which Rudolf Otto's *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* resolves

into self-consuming apotheosis by light, fire, or air.

Drawing on Weber, Agamben, Bataille, Girard, Frazer, Eliade, Benjamin, Horkheimer and Adorno, Lacan, Kristeva, Charles Taylor, and Philippe Descola, and situating Eggers among his sources (early modern demonology, Saxo Grammaticus and the Eddic corpus, Poe, Melville, Sarah Orne Jewett, Stoker, Murnau) and his generic kin (Dreyer, Bergman, Vláčil, Shindō, Hardy, Aster, Lowery), the dissertation contends that the horror of these films is neither supernatural intrusion nor the return of the repressed but ontological re-possession: the transient conversion of the spectator's "buffered" modern self into the "porous" self of an abolished cosmos. Eggers's cinema thereby emerges as an anthropology of the modern subject composed from the standpoint of what that subject must expel in order to constitute itself—the animal, the sacred, the sovereign feminine, the outlaw, and the dead. A concluding prospective reading of the forthcoming *Werwulf*, set in the century in which English law codified the outlaw as one who "bears the wolf's head" (*caput gerit lupinum*), treats that film as the structural test of the lycanthropic hypothesis.

Contents

Introduction: *Lupus in Fabula* 5

I. The Archive and the Altar: Hierophantic Realism 12

II. The Clearing and the Covenant: *The Witch* 21

III. The Keeper and the Light: *The Lighthouse* 30

IV. The Thread and the Wound: *The Northman* 39

V. The Bride and the Plague: *Nosferatu* 49

VI. The Eggersian Constellation: Comparative Mythopoetics . . . 57

VII. Lycanthropology: An Original Synthesis 65

Conclusion: The Hour of the Wolf 77

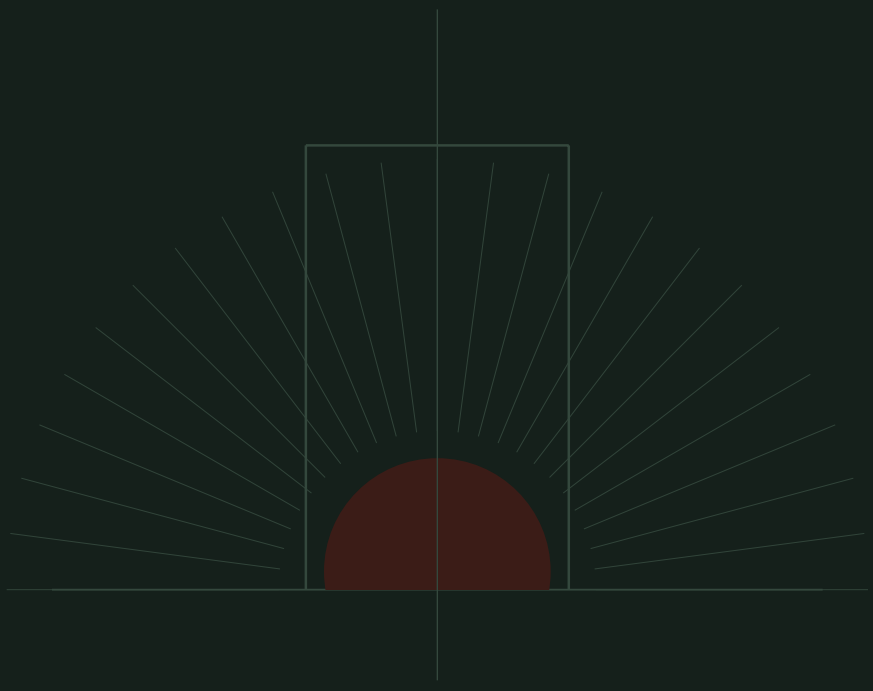
Selected Bibliography 80

Keywords 92

Introduction

Lupus in Fabula

Problem, wager, apparatus, method



I. The Problem of the Corpus

The four completed features of Robert Eggers form not a sequence of period horror films but a single sustained argument about the constitution of the modern subject, and the task of this dissertation is to reconstruct that argument and to name it. Born in New York City in 1983 and raised in rural New Hampshire, within an hour's drive of Salem, Eggers came to cinema through the theatre, as a designer and director of small-scale stage productions in New York; the origin myth he has repeatedly narrated is a juvenile stage adaptation of F. W. Murnau's *Nosferatu*, mounted while he was still in high school (Wikipedia). Between 2015 and 2024 he released four features whose settings span roughly a millennium and three cultural zones: *The Witch* (Sundance 2015, where it received the Directing Award; released by A24 in 2016), set in Puritan New England around 1630; *The Lighthouse* (Cannes, Directors' Fortnight, 2019), set on a rock off the New England coast in the 1890s; *The Northman* (Focus Features, 2022), set in the North Atlantic between AD 895 and the early tenth century; and *Nosferatu* (Focus Features, 2024), set in the fictional Baltic port of Wisborg in 1838. A fifth, *Werwulf*, co-written once more with the Icelandic poet and novelist Sjón and set in thirteenth-century England, is scheduled for release on 25 December 2026 (The Hollywood Reporter; Focus Features).

Critical reception has organized this corpus around three frames, each of which captures a surface and misses a structure. The first, the industrial-aesthetic category of "elevated horror" or "post-horror," is at bottom a sociology of taste: it describes a mode of distribution, a festival pedigree, and a repertoire of formal markers (slowness, ambiguity, austerity) through which a disreputable genre petitions for cultural legitimacy (Church 2021). It explains why *The Witch* was marketed as it was; it cannot explain why a Viking revenge epic and a Biedermeier vampire melodrama belong to the same œuvre. The second, the "folk horror revival," usefully foregrounds the landscape, isolation, and skewed belief systems that Adam Scovell (2017) identifies as the links of the genre's "chain," but it fits *The Witch* far better than *The Lighthouse* or *Nosferatu*, and it presupposes an outsider's gaze upon an archaic enclave that, as Chapter Six demonstrates, Eggers systematically refuses. The third, the discourse of historical authenticity, takes the director at his paratextual word, catalogues the

research apparatus (period-sourced dialogue, hand-woven textiles, natural and candle light, archaic film stocks), and mistakes the means of the films for their end.

What all three frames leave unexplained is the paradox that constitutes this study's point of departure. The more exactly Eggers reconstructs the past, the less historical his films become. A method of the most scrupulous historicism—the documentary ambition to show the past, in Leopold von Ranke's formula, *wie es eigentlich gewesen*—yields an effect of the most radical anti-historicism: a past that refuses to remain past and presses upon the present with the urgency of a summons. Fidelity produces not distance but possession. The question this dissertation pursues is why.

II. Lupus in Fabula: The Wager

Terence's *Adelphoe* (l. 537) preserves a Roman idiom, *lupus in fabula*—"the wolf in the story"—spoken when the very person under discussion appears. Beneath the proverb lies an older apotropaic logic, attested in Virgil's ninth *Eclogue* and in Pliny's *Natural History* (8.80), according to which the wolf that sees a man before he sees it robs him of his voice: to speak of the wolf is to summon it; to be seen by the wolf is to fall silent. The idiom serves as this dissertation's emblem for three reasons. It names the performative power of speech that Eggers's archival dialogue exploits, in which period language functions less as information than as invocation. It names the folktale, the form *The Witch* claims in its very subtitle, as the medium through which the excluded returns. And it names the wolf, the figure toward which the entire corpus has been moving, from the wolf-warriors of *The Northman* to the explicit lycanthropy of *Werwulf*.

The wager is that Eggers's films are best understood as a lycanthropology: an anthropology of the modern subject written from the standpoint of the wolf. The coinage must be distinguished from *lycanthropia*, the melancholic delusion described by Paul of Aegina in the seventh century and catalogued by Robert Burton in *The Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621) as a species of "wolf-madness." It designates instead a counter-anthropology. Giorgio Agamben (2002) has described the "anthropological machine" by which Western thought produces the human through the incessant exclusion of the animal within it, and he has located the juridical prototype of that exclusion in the Germanic outlaw who "bears the wolf's head" and may be killed with impunity

(Agamben 1995). Eggers's films run that machine in reverse. They begin from the order that excludes—covenant, contract, kingship, bourgeois medicine—and follow the excluded subject across the threshold into the zone of the wolf, the witch, the siren, and the revenant, where the human order discovers its own founding violence and the spectator discovers the price of his own humanity.

III. Conceptual Apparatus

Eight concepts organize the argument. They are introduced here schematically and developed in the chapters that follow.

Hierophantic realism designates Eggers's aesthetic regime: the deployment of maximal material, linguistic, and photographic verisimilitude not as an end but as the medium of a hierophany, in Mircea Eliade's sense of a manifestation of the sacred within the profane. Where magical realism renders the marvelous matter-of-fact and the Todorovian fantastic suspends the spectator between natural and supernatural explanation, hierophantic realism supplies, through archival exactitude, the faith that the marvelous presupposes and that the modern spectator lacks.

The threshold of disenchantment names the historical location of each film: a moment at which an enchanted ontology is being displaced by a rationalizing order, in Max Weber's sense of the *Entzauberung der Welt*. Each setting is chosen with structural precision at such a threshold, and the corpus, reordered by diegetic chronology, reconstructs a genealogy of disenchantment.

The ban, after Agamben's reading of the archaic *bannum*, names the act by which an order constitutes itself by excluding a life that it abandons outside the law while holding it in relation to the law. Every Eggers protagonist is a creature of the ban: a banished family, a fugitive living under a dead man's name, an exiled prince who sells himself into slavery, a bride diagnosed, confined, and finally offered up.

Initiation without return designates the narrative form. Arnold van Gennep (1909) analyzed rites of passage into three phases—separation, liminality, reaggregation—and Victor Turner (1967; 1969) theorized the liminal phase as a condition "betwixt and between," symbolically assimilated to death, the womb, the wilderness, and invisibility. Eggers's narratives preserve the first two phases with ethnographic precision and displace the third: reaggregation occurs not into the social order but into the numinous.

The anomalous mediator names the animal—goat, hare, raven, gull, wolf, fox, rat, horse—that conducts the passage across the threshold. The concept synthesizes Claude Lévi-Strauss's analysis of carrion-eaters as mythic mediators between life and death, Mary Douglas's anomalous sacred animal, Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's "anomal" with which the sorcerer forms his pact at the edge of the pack, and Noël Carroll's categorically interstitial monster.

The threshold-sovereign names the feminine figure who administers passage between orders of being. The concept transposes Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception from the juridical to the ontological register, and it is advanced against two dominant readings: Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, which makes woman the abject other of patriarchal order, and Jules Michelet's emancipated witch, which makes her its heroic adversary.

Terminal ecstasy names the form of consummation: a climax in which *ekstasis*, the standing-outside-oneself of the mystic and the shaman, coincides with annihilation. Rudolf Otto's numinous, at once *tremendum* and *fascinans*, is resolved in each film into a self-consuming apotheosis by light, fire, or air.

Ontological re-possession, finally, names the spectatorial effect. Charles Taylor (2007) distinguishes the "porous" self of the premodern world, open to spirits, demons, and cosmic forces, from the "buffered" self of secular modernity. Eggers's cinema temporarily converts the latter into the former. Its horror is neither the intrusion of the supernatural into a natural world nor, in Robin Wood's (1979) influential formula, the return of the repressed; it is the experience of being, for the duration of the film, possessed by a cosmos that modernity believed it had abolished.

IV. Method

The method is what Agamben (2008) calls paradigmatic: each film is treated as a singular case that, without ceasing to be singular, renders intelligible a larger problematic whole, moving by analogy from singular to singular rather than by induction or deduction. Four disciplines are braided into that method. *Quellenforschung* identifies the documentary and literary sources from which the films are built: Puritan sermons and witchcraft pamphlets, Saxo Grammaticus and the Eddic corpus, Poe, Melville, Jewett, Stoker, and Murnau. Comparative mythology, disciplined by Georges Dumézil's insistence on structural rather than diffusionist comparison, situates those sources within wider Indo-European and Christian mythic grammars. Psychoanalysis is employed as a hermeneutic of structure rather than an etiology of characters: it reads the economies of desire, prohibition, and enjoyment that the films stage, not the case histories of fictional persons. Formal analysis, finally, treats light, duration, aspect ratio, and frontality as bearers of meaning in their own right.

Two cautions follow. First, the linguist Kenneth Pike's (1954) distinction between *emic* description, from within a cultural system, and *etic* description, from outside it, structures the films' own ambition: Eggers aspires to an emic cinema. This dissertation is necessarily etic, and its claim is precisely that the films' emic ambition produces effects that only an etic reading can name. Second, Eggers's interviews are treated as paratexts in Gérard Genette's sense—thresholds of interpretation, not its authority. The intentional fallacy (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946) is honored not as dogma but as discipline: what the films do takes precedence over what their maker says they do.

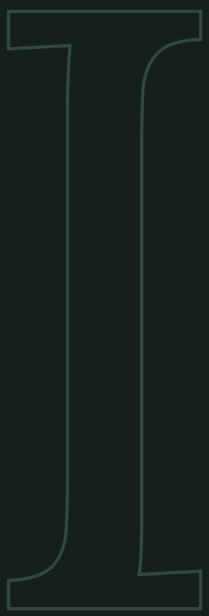
V. Plan of the Dissertation

Chapter One theorizes hierophantic realism through Eggers's treatment of language, light, duration, and performance. Chapters Two through Five offer close readings of the four completed features, each organized around the threshold of disenchantment at which the film is set and the traditions from which it is built: Calvinist covenant theology and early modern demonology (*The Witch*); Frazerian ritualism, Hegelian lordship, and the Promethean myth of modern labor (*The Lighthouse*); Norse fatalism, sacral kingship, and Girardian mimesis (*The Northman*); Romantic medicine, the political economy of the vampire, and the erotics of sacrifice (*Nosferatu*). Chapter Six situates Eggers among works of folk horror, the vampire tradition, Northern mythological fiction, and the art cinema of the sacred, and proposes a distinction between exogenous and endogenous folk horror. Chapter Seven assembles the original synthesis: it reconstructs the corpus as a counter-genealogy of disenchantment, formalizes the six invariants of what it calls the lycanthropic dispositif, and closes with a prospective reading of *Werwulf* as the structural test of the hypothesis. The Conclusion returns to the hour in which all of Eggers's rites are consummated: the hour between night and dawn that Bergman's *Vargtimmen* (1968), invoking Scandinavian folk belief, called the hour of the wolf.

The Archive and the Altar

Hierophantic Realism

Language, light, duration, performance



Eggers's historical method is a liturgy disguised as an archive: its exactitude does not represent the past but consecrates it, converting documentary fidelity into the condition of possibility of a hierophany. This chapter reconstructs the mechanism of that conversion across four registers—historiography, ontology, language, and the photographic image—and concludes with the repertory of performers through which the rite is repeated across epochs.

1.1 Ranke's Dictum and Benjamin's Danger

The surface of Eggers's method is Rankean to the point of obsession. *The Witch* closes with a title card acknowledging that much of its dialogue derives directly from period journals, diaries, and court records; its farmstead was raised by period timber-framing techniques in the Ontario backwoods. *The Lighthouse* erected a working light tower on Cape Forchu, Nova Scotia. *The Northman* reconstructed longhouses, a Slavic stockade, and the ritual apparatus of a sacral king's hall in consultation with specialists in Viking-Age archaeology and Old Norse literature. *Nosferatu* rebuilt a Hanseatic port town, down to its period ironmongery and its fever-ward linens. The ambition, in Ranke's celebrated formulation, is to show the past *wie es eigentlich gewesen*.

Yet the effect of this Rankean labor is precisely the one Walter Benjamin opposed to Ranke in the sixth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940). To articulate the past historically, Benjamin argued, is not to know it as it really was but to seize hold of a memory as it flashes up *im Augenblick einer Gefahr*, at a moment of danger. Historicism, for Benjamin, was the empathic method of the victor: it pacified the past by sealing it into a homogeneous, empty time from which it could no longer address the present. Eggers inverts the Benjaminian polarity without abandoning its stakes. He uses the historicist's instruments to produce the historical materialist's effect. The density of the reconstructed past does not seal it into the past; on the contrary, the very completeness of the reconstruction removes the historiographic frame that ordinarily distances us from it. There is no narrator, no framing present, no modern surrogate, no anachronistic irony. The past is not shown *as past*. It is shown as a present that happens to be ours no longer, and therein lies its danger.

1.2 The Emic Camera and the Ontological Turn

The linguist Kenneth Pike's (1954) distinction between emic and etic description, derived from the opposition between phonemics and phonetics, has become the anthropologist's shorthand for the difference between describing a culture in its own categories and describing it in the observer's. Eggers's cinema aspires to the emic. But its true novelty lies in a stronger commitment, which aligns it with the so-called "ontological turn" in contemporary anthropology. Eduardo Viveiros de Castro (1998), and after him Martin Holbraad and Morten Axel Pedersen (2017), have argued that ethnography errs whenever it translates the worlds of others into "beliefs" about a single world that the ethnographer alone perceives correctly. To take others seriously is to treat their statements as descriptions of the worlds they inhabit rather than as representations, true or false, of ours.

Eggers takes this step cinematically. In *The Witch*, the infant Samuel is abducted and slaughtered by a witch within the first act, in shots that admit no subjective mediation. The decision forecloses the epistemological question that governs most witchcraft fiction—is she really a witch?—and substitutes the ontological one: what follows if she is? The Puritan family's world is not presented as a set of beliefs, some of them superstitious, but as a world, and the film's camera inhabits it on its terms. The same decision governs *The Northman*, whose Valkyrie rides the sky without ironic frame, and *Nosferatu*, whose revenant is no allegory of disease but a dead sorcerer with an itinerary and a contract.

Philippe Descola's (2005) typology of ontologies permits a more exact description. Descola distinguishes four schemes of identification according to whether beings are held to share or differ in their interiorities and their physicalities: *animism* (shared interiority, differing physicalities), *totemism* (shared interiority and physicality within a group), *analogism* (discontinuity of both, bridged by networks of correspondence), and *naturalism* (shared physicality, with interiority reserved to humans), the last being the peculiar ontology of the modern West. Each of Eggers's films stages a collision among these schemes, and in each the more modern ontology is defeated. In *The Witch*, the analogist cosmos of Puritan providentialism—in which every blighted ear of corn and every hare in the thicket is a sign to be read, as in Increase Mather's *Essay for the Recording of Illustrious Providences* (1684)—is besieged by a forest that behaves animistically, populated by

beasts who are persons. In *The Lighthouse*, the naturalism of the wage contract, the federal logbook, and the Fresnel lens fissures under the pressure of an older maritime animism in which gulls house the souls of drowned sailors. In *The Northman*, an animist-analogist world of plural souls (*hugr*, *hamr*, *fylgja*, *hamingja*) and cosmic correspondences meets the nascent naturalism of a political economy of slaves and silver. In *Nosferatu*, the analogism of Paracelsian occult science, embodied in Willem Dafoe's Professor von Franz, defeats the naturalism of academic medicine, embodied in Ralph Ineson's Dr. Sievers. The corpus, so read, is a Descolan atlas of ontological collisions in which modernity loses every battle it would win in the history books.

1.3 Speech as Resurrection: The Sacrament of Language

The most conspicuous instrument of Eggers's hierophantic realism is language. *The Witch* speaks an Early Modern English assembled from Caroline sermons, catechisms, and witchcraft depositions, whose second-person intimacies (*thee*, *thou*, *wouldst*) carry the cadence of the Authorized Version. *The Lighthouse* braids the coastal Maine idiom recorded in Sarah Orne Jewett's fiction with the oceanic rhetoric of Melville and a Miltonic grandiloquence reserved for curses. *The Northman* casts its English in the syntax of saga prose and the compression of skaldic kennings, punctuated by Old Norse and Old East Slavic in its ritual passages. *Nosferatu* sets the German-inflected English of a Biedermeier town against the archaic, estranged speech of its sorcerer-count. *Werwulf*, according to pre-release reporting, takes the principle to its limit with dialogue composed in Middle English with the assistance of two Oxford scholars (World of Reel).

The function of this archival speech is not primarily communicative. J. L. Austin (1962) distinguished constative utterances, which describe states of affairs and are true or false, from performative utterances, which accomplish acts—promising, cursing, marrying, naming—and are felicitous or infelicitous. Eggers's period dialogue is performative in a double sense. Within the diegesis, it is a language of binding: oaths, covenants, curses, prayers, contracts. Toward the spectator, it is a language of summoning: its strangeness obliges attention, slows comprehension to the pace of liturgy, and transforms the hearing of speech into something closer to the hearing of an incantation.

Giorgio Agamben's *The Sacrament of Language* (2008) supplies the deeper frame. Agamben argues that the oath is not a late juridical or

religious institution but the anthropogenic act itself: the act by which the speaking animal first binds itself to the truth and efficacy of its own words, staking its life upon the correspondence of word and deed. The oath's obverse is the curse, which falls upon the perjurer; blessing and malediction are its two faces. Every Eggers film is, before anything else, a drama of the sworn word. *The Witch* opens with a covenant community and ends with the signing of the Devil's book. *The Lighthouse* turns on a labor contract, a logbook in which one man writes the other's fate, and a curse hurled in the name of Neptune. *The Northman* is structured from beginning to end by a boy's tripartite vow. *Nosferatu* is set in motion by a girl's prayer and a property contract signed by a man who cannot read its language. The plots of the films are the working-out of performatives, and their horror is the horror of the anthropogenic bond made visible: the discovery that words bind, and that what they bind may be oneself.

1.4 The Photochemical Liturgy: Night, Duration, Frontality

The second instrument is light. Eggers's cinematographer Jarin Blaschke has consistently restricted illumination to what the diegetic world could plausibly provide: daylight filtered through overcast and smoke, the hearth, the tallow candle, the oil lamp, the lantern's cone. *The Lighthouse* intensifies the principle by shooting on black-and-white negative through a custom filter that emulates the spectral response of nineteenth-century orthochromatic stock, in the near-square 1.19:1 ratio of early sound cinema. The principle may be stated as an axiom: *the camera sees only what the epoch's light permits*. Its consequence is the restoration of premodern night.

Wolfgang Schivelbusch (1983) has shown that the industrialization of light in the nineteenth century—gas, then electricity—constituted a literal "disenchantment of the night," dissolving the nocturnal realm in which, as A. Roger Ekirch (2005) has documented, early modern Europeans located witches, spirits, thieves, and the dead. Eggers reverses Schivelbusch's history. His films re-enchant the night by refusing it the anachronistic light that modern cinema routinely supplies. The forest beyond the clearing, the darkness below the lamp, the black interior of the burial mound, the shuttered bedchamber of a plague town: these are not stylistic gloom but ontological restorations. Darkness in Eggers is the darkness in which the premodern sacred lived, and the films' refusal to illuminate it is a refusal to disenchant it.

The third instrument is duration. Eggers favors long takes and slow, processional push-ins, in which the camera advances toward a sacred object—the goat, the lamp, the Seeress, the bride's bed—with the deliberation of a celebrant approaching an altar. Andrei Tarkovsky (1986) spoke of "sculpting in time" and of the pressure of time within the shot; Eliade (1957) distinguished the homogeneous time of the profane from the reversible, recoverable time of ritual, in which the mythic event becomes present again. Eggers's duration belongs to the second order. It does not represent the time of an action; it imposes the time of a rite.

The fourth instrument is frontality. Eggers repeatedly composes in symmetrical, frontal tableaux, in which the figure faces the lens as an icon faces the faithful. Pavel Florensky's *Iconostasis* (1922) argued that the Orthodox icon's "reverse perspective" places the beholder within the sacred space rather than before it: the icon is not a window onto an object but a site from which the holy looks out. Eggers's frontal compositions—Black Phillip in the byre doorway, Wake's face streaming light in the hypnotic tableau modeled on Sascha Schneider's Symbolist imagery, the Seeress in her shell-strewn chamber, Orlok's silhouette at the window—produce the same reversal. The image looks back. Paul Schrader's "transcendental style" (1972; rev. 2018) described a progression from a sparse everyday through a moment of disparity to a final stasis that intimates the transcendent. Eggers inverts every term. His everyday is not sparse but saturated; his disparity is not a rupture of tone but a hierophany; and his stasis is not serenity but terminal ecstasy, a final tableau of consumption. The result may be called *transcendental horror*: a style in which the transcendent is reached, and is the *tremendum*.

1.5 Beyond the Fantastic: Todorov, Carpentier, and the Prosthesis of Faith

Tzvetan Todorov (1970) defined the fantastic as the hesitation, experienced by a reader who knows only the laws of nature, before an event apparently supernatural. If the event is ultimately explained, the text passes into the *uncanny*; if the supernatural is accepted, into the *marvelous*. The Gothic tradition codified both exits. Ann Radcliffe's "explained supernatural" dissolved every apparition into machinery, and Benjamin Christensen's *Häxan* (1922) rationalized the early modern witch as a misdiagnosed hysteric. Eggers forecloses hesitation as early as he can and exits, without apology, into the marvelous.

The single partial exception is instructive. *The Lighthouse* sustains Todorovian hesitation to its last frame: no reading can decide whether the mermaid, the tentacled Proteus, and the Promethean gulls are hallucination, myth, or fact. It is also the film set at the most disenchanted of Eggers's thresholds, the industrial 1890s. The correlation is not accidental. The degree of hesitation in each film corresponds to the degree of disenchantment of its diegetic world. Where the epoch believes, the camera believes; where the epoch has begun to doubt, the camera doubts with it. Eggers's cinema thus possesses what may be called an *epochal epistemology*: the film's mode of knowing is calibrated to the mode of knowing of the world it depicts.

Alejo Carpentier's prologue to *El reino de este mundo* (1949) supplies the decisive concept. Distinguishing his *real maravilloso* from the manufactured marvels of European Surrealism, Carpentier insisted that the sensation of the marvelous presupposes faith: those who do not believe in saints cannot be cured by their miracles. Franz Roh's *Magischer Realismus* (1925) and the Latin American magical realism that followed could render the marvelous matter-of-fact because they addressed, or simulated, a believing community. Eggers addresses a disbelieving one. His solution is to manufacture the missing faith through the archive. The density of verifiable detail—the correct stitch, the correct idiom, the correct quality of tallow light—solicits the spectator's credence at the level of the material, and that credence, once extended to the material, cannot be withheld from the marvelous without incoherence. Credibility migrates from the loom to the goat. Archival fidelity is a *prosthesis of faith*.

Hierophantic realism may now be defined. It is the aesthetic regime in which (1) maximal material, linguistic, and photographic fidelity (2)

forecloses Todorovian hesitation to the degree that the depicted epoch itself forecloses it, (3) presents the sacred as an ontological fact within the diegesis, and (4) transfers the spectator's credence from the documentary surface to the numinous event, thereby (5) producing in the modern spectator an ontological dissonance experienced as horror. Eliade observed that for modern humanity the sacred survives only camouflaged in the profane. Hierophantic realism is the technique of decamouflage.

1.6 The Repertory as Ritual Troupe

The rite is performed by a recurring troupe. Willem Dafoe has appeared in every Eggers feature since *The Lighthouse*: as Thomas Wake, keeper of the light; as Heimir the Fool, master of the initiation rite and later an oracular severed head in the manner of Mímir; as Professor Albin Eberhart von Franz, the occult scholar who identifies the vampire and prescribes the sacrifice; and, per announced casting, in *Werwulf*. In each role he is the corpus's hierophant and psychopomp, the figure who knows the other order and conducts others toward it. His star body carries an intertextual charge that the films exploit: Dafoe played Christ in Martin Scorsese's *The Last Temptation of Christ* (1988) and Max Schreck, the original Orlok, in E. Elias Merhige's *Shadow of the Vampire* (2000). The actor who has embodied both the incarnate God and the first screen Nosferatu already contains the two poles of Eggers's cosmos.

Around him the troupe distributes stock functions. Ralph Ineson's basso profundo is the voice of an authority that cannot protect: the disgraced patriarch William, the Rus' war-captain Volodymyr, the helpless physician Sievers. Anya Taylor-Joy is the initiate who knows another order: Thomasin, who signs the Devil's book, and Olga of the Birch Forest, the Slavic sorceress. Kate Dickie is the mother and the servant, Katherine and Halldóra. Aaron Taylor-Johnson and Lily-Rose Depp, the bourgeois husband's friend and the bride of *Nosferatu*, return in *Werwulf* credited simply as "Man" and "Woman" (The Hollywood Reporter). The troupe functions less like a stock company than like the officiants of a liturgical calendar, who assume different vestments for different feasts while performing a single rite. The migration of the same bodies across a millennium of settings produces a quasi-metempsychotic effect, as though each film were a reincarnation of one ceremony. The designations "Man" and "Woman" complete the

logic: the repertory sheds its proper names and becomes, as in the morality play, *Everyman*.

The Clearing and the Covenant

The Witch

Set in New England, around 1630
Premiered 2015

II

The Witch is a tragedy of the covenant: it shows a Calvinist family, banished from the community of the elect, discovering that the only assurance of election available in the New England wilderness is the one the Devil offers. This chapter reads the film as the first and purest instance of the lycanthropic structure, in which a ban at the origin opens a liminal interval that closes not in reintegration but in ascent.

2.1 The Ban at the Origin

The film is set around 1630, the year the Winthrop fleet carried the Massachusetts Bay Company to New England and the year to which tradition assigns John Winthrop's lay sermon *A Modell of Christian Charity*, with its covenantal promise that the plantation "shall be as a city upon a hill." The film's first act is a judicial expulsion from that city. William, arraigned before the plantation's elders, refuses their correction in the name of a purer gospel; he is banished, and his household follows him beyond the palisade. The historical type is precise. In the decade that followed, banishment became the Bay Colony's standard instrument against the godly-too-godly: Roger Williams was sentenced in 1635, Anne Hutchinson and the Antinomians in 1637–38. William belongs to this lineage of the excessively elect, whose sin is not deficiency of zeal but its surplus, the pride of a conscience that will not be governed.

Agamben's analysis of the ban illuminates what follows. The banished life, he argues, is not simply expelled from the order but abandoned by it, exposed and held in relation to the law in the very act of exclusion (Agamben 1995). William's family is outside the covenant community yet wholly within its law. They pray, catechize, examine their consciences, and dread damnation with greater intensity than before, because the corporate means of grace—the congregation, the ministry, the magistrate—have been withdrawn from them. Their farm, set in a clearing at the edge of the forest, is a zone of indistinction between the polis and the wilderness. William Bradford had described the coast the Pilgrims reached as "a hideous and desolate wilderness, full of wild beasts and wild men," and Cotton Mather would describe New England as the people of God settled in what were once "the Devils Territories" (*The Wonders of the Invisible World*, 1693). The family's errand into the wilderness, cut loose from the corporate errand Perry Miller (1956) reconstructed, becomes private, desperate, and finally diabolical.

The colony's own archive supplied a template for the maternal horror that follows. When Mary Dyer was delivered of a malformed stillborn in 1637 and Anne Hutchinson of what physicians would now recognize as a molar pregnancy in 1638, Winthrop recorded both as "monstrous births," divine judgments manifest in the wombs of heterodox women (*A Short Story of the Rise, Reign, and Ruine of the Antinomians*, 1644). Heterodoxy, femininity, maternity, and monstrosity were already fused in the theology of the plantation that expels the film's family.

2.2 The Weberian Vacuum: Disenchantment as Disarmament

Max Weber located in Puritanism the completion of the "elimination of magic from the world" that had begun with the Hebrew prophets. Rejecting every sacramental means to salvation, Calvinism left the believer in what Weber called an unprecedented inner loneliness before an inscrutable God (Weber 1904–05). Keith Thomas (1971) supplied the social corollary. By abolishing the protective magic of the medieval Church—holy water, consecrated bells, exorcism, the intercession of saints—the Reformation stripped the laity of ritual defenses against *maleficium* and left them three recourses: prayer, fasting, and the prosecution of the witch.

The Witch stages this condition with diagrammatic clarity. The banished family has no church, no minister, no magistrate, and no cunning-folk; its armory consists of psalms, prayers, and accusation. When the domestic order collapses, the family convenes, in effect, a witch-trial without a court, turning upon its eldest daughter the only weapon its theology has left it. The film's insight may be stated as a thesis on Weber: *Puritanism disenchanted the believer's means without disenchanting his world.* Its disenchantment was a disarmament. Stuart Clark (1997) has shown that early modern demonology was not an irrational residue but a coherent science of inversion, in which the witch was intelligible as the systematic reversal of godly order. The family inhabits a world in which that science is true and lacks every instrument but the one—accusation—that accelerates its destruction.

2.3 Election and Its Anxieties

Calvin himself called the decree of double predestination *decretum horribile* (*Institutes* III.23.7), and the horror was experiential before it was doctrinal. Because election could not be earned, it could only be inferred from signs, and English practical divinity—from William Perkins's casuistry of assurance to the conversion "relations" through which New England churches admitted their members, analyzed by Edmund Morgan in *Visible Saints* (1963)—became a vast hermeneutic of the self, an anxious reading of one's own heart for marks of grace.

The film's first wound is theological. The infant Samuel vanishes unbaptized, and Caleb's anguished question whether his brother now dwells in Hell is answered by his father only with a doctrine of submission. Michael Wigglesworth's *The Day of Doom* (1662), the best-selling poem of seventeenth-century New England, would resolve the question by assigning reprobate infants "the easiest room in Hell." Thomasin's nocturnal prayer, a catalogue of Sabbath-breaking, idleness, and disobedience, is an authentic specimen of Puritan self-examination; its sincerity is the measure of its failure, for no examination can yield certainty.

The finale must be read against this economy. Black Phillip offers Thomasin butter, a pretty dress, the sight of the world, and then poses the question "Wouldst thou like to live deliciously?" The phrase is not period color but scripture inverted. In the Authorized Version, it is the Whore of Babylon who "glorified herself, and lived deliciously" (Rev. 18:7), and the kings of the earth who "lived deliciously with her" (18:9); in Puritan typology, Babylon was Rome, the Church of sensuous ritual and luxury that the Reformation had expelled. The dress answers the Bay Colony's sumptuary legislation of 1634; the butter answers the land flowing with milk and honey (Exod. 3:8), here inverted by a nanny goat that yields blood; the offer of the world reprises the third temptation of Christ in the wilderness (Matt. 4:8–9), which Thomasin, unlike Christ, accepts. The Devil speaks a scriptural cento in reverse. And what he grants is exactly what the Calvinist God withheld: *assurance*. He names her desire, guides her hand, receives her into a visible congregation of the elect, and lifts her bodily into the air. The levitation is the outward sign of election that the Puritan soul craved and could never obtain, made literal. *The only assurance of election that the film dispenses is diabolical.*

2.4 The Maternal Body and the Economy of Witchcraft

The film's demonology is organized around the maternal body, and here its debts to the historiography of witchcraft are profound. Lyndal Roper (1994; 2004) demonstrated that witchcraft accusations in early modern Germany frequently originated in the lying-in chamber, where post-partum mothers and their attendants projected onto older women fantasies of envious, infant-killing anti-maternity; the witch was a nightmare about the mother's body. The witch of the film steals an unbaptized infant and renders him into flying ointment, a detail that faithfully reproduces learned demonology: Giambattista della Porta's *Magia Naturalis* (1558) and Francis Bacon's *Sylva Sylvarum* (1627) both report ointments compounded of infants' fat. Katherine's grief culminates in the film's most terrible inversion, when, believing she nurses Samuel, she suckles a raven that tears her breast. The image condenses the English trial obsession with the "witch's teat" at which familiars were said to feed, searched for on the bodies of the accused by Matthew Hopkins in 1645–47, and reverses the flow of the maternal economy: milk becomes blood, nursing becomes predation, the mother becomes the witch's double.

Thomasin's menarche is the hinge of the domestic plot. Her mother announces it to her father as the reason she must be "put out" into service with another household, a Puritan custom documented by Morgan in *The Puritan Family* (1944). Sexual maturity converts the daughter into a disturbance within the household economy: the object of her brother's furtive gaze, of her mother's rivalry, of her siblings' accusation. The twins' charge reproduces the paradigm of the bewitched children that runs from the Throckmorton girls of Warboys (1593) through the Goodwin children of Boston (1688) to Salem (1692). Carol Karlsen (1987) showed that New England's accused witches were disproportionately women positioned anomalously with respect to property and male authority; the film miniaturizes her thesis in the episode of Katherine's silver cup, inherited from her father, sold by William for traps, and blamed on Thomasin. Malcolm Gaskill's reconstruction of the 1651 Springfield case of Hugh and Mary Parsons (2021), in which a frontier marriage consumed itself in mutual accusation and a mother confessed to killing her own infant by witchcraft, is the documentary record closest to the film's domestic witch-hunt.

Silvia Federici (2004) read the European witch-hunt as an instrument of primitive accumulation, a war on women's control of their bodies and reproductive capacities that disciplined the female body into the unpaid labor of the emerging capitalist household. Federici's frame captures Thomasin's domestic servitude—the laundering, the goat-tending, the minding of children—and gives her flight the shape of an exodus. The film, however, refuses the consolation. The coven to which Thomasin flees is not a commons but a cannibal economy that feeds on infants, consuming the very reproductive future from which she escapes. The sabbat is not the commons; it is the commons' nightmare. Julia Kristeva's (1980) abject and Barbara Creed's (1993) monstrous-feminine, which locate horror at the boundary of the maternal body, describe Katherine's trajectory exactly. They do not describe Thomasin's. For Thomasin, the abject is not a boundary to be policed but a threshold to be crossed, and its crossing is sovereignty.

2.5 Black Phillip: The Goat, the Pact, and the Signature

Black Phillip condenses three millennia of caprine theology. Leviticus 16 prescribes two goats for the Day of Atonement, one for the Lord and one "for Azazel," sent into the wilderness bearing the community's sins. Black Phillip inverts the scapegoat: he does not carry the family's sins into the wilderness but serves as the wilderness's envoy, collecting them where they lie. Behind him stand Pan, whose death Plutarch reported and whom Christian exegesis made the herald of Christ's advent; the he-goat enthroned among witches in Goya's *El Aquelarre* (1797–98) and the Black Paintings; Éliphas Lévi's Baphomet (1856); and Arthur Machen's *The Great God Pan* (1894), whose heroine is born of a woman's union with the goat-god. The twins' nursery chant to their goat is the film's parody of liturgy, and its truth.

The pact is an inverted covenant. Seventeenth-century New England confessions, most famously Tituba's at Salem in 1692, describe the signing of the Devil's book; the godly, meanwhile, "owned the covenant" through public relations of conversion. Thomasin cannot write, and the Devil guides her hand. The detail carries the whole weight of Puritan textual culture, in which literacy existed for scripture and covenant was a written bond. It also stages, with startling literalness, the paradox Jacques Derrida (1972) located in every signature: that the mark by which a singular presence binds itself is iterable, repeatable, and therefore always already guided by another. Thomasin's signature is

written by the Other, and so, the film suggests, is everyone's.

The ending's ideological valence has divided its audiences. The Satanic Temple publicly championed the film, reading it in the tradition of Jules Michelet's *La Sorcière* (1862), which made the witch the priestess of nature and the people against Church and lord, and of William Blake's inversion of Milton, in which the Devil's party speaks for energy and desire and "the road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom." Others have read the ending as the confirmation of the Puritan nightmare, the elders' fear of the ungoverned daughter made flesh. Both readings are correct, and their coincidence is the film's formal genius. The ending is the precise realization of a liberation fantasy and the precise realization of a persecutory fantasy, and the two cannot be separated, because the banned subject fulfills the order's fantasy of her in the very act of escaping it. This coincidence is the logic of the ban, and it will recur in every film that follows.

2.6 Gretel in Reverse: The Folktale and Its Inversion

The subtitle, A *New-England Folktale*, is a generic claim to be taken literally. Eggers's first substantial short film was an adaptation of *Hansel and Gretel* (2007), and *The Witch* is that tale's inversion. In the Grimms' version (KHM 15, 1812)—in which, before later editions softened her into a stepmother, it was the children's own mother who urged their abandonment—two siblings lost in the forest are lured by an edible house, and Gretel delivers them by pushing the witch into her own oven. In *The Witch*, the brother is lured into the forest hovel by a beautiful woman, the house of sweets displaced into erotic allure; he returns to vomit a whole apple, the fruit of Eden, and dies in an ecstasy of Christ-directed love. The sister does not push the witch into the oven. She becomes the witch. Vladimir Propp's (1928) morphology confirms the inversion: the tale opens with the canonical function of villainy (the abduction of a child), passes through the donor's provision of a magical agent, and concludes with the hero's wedding and accession, here transfigured into Thomasin's reception and ascension in the inverted kingdom.

Bruno Bettelheim (1976) read Hansel and Gretel as the child's overcoming of oral dependence and the devouring mother through cooperation and maturity; Marina Warner (1994; 1998) read the ogress as the shadow of maternal power and the female storyteller as a half-witch. Eggers's inversion leaves no maturation into the social

order: maturation is into witchhood. The tale's nearest literary siblings are Angela Carter's "The Company of Wolves" (1979), whose heroine, nobody's meat, undresses and laughs in the wolf's face before lying down beside him, and Nathaniel Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown" (1835), whose Puritan protagonist finds the whole godly community gathered at a forest sabbath and returns faithless. Thomasin is Goodman Brown who does not return. Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904), the diary of a girl initiated into a hidden sorcery, and Carl Theodor Dreyer's *Day of Wrath* (1943), whose young pastor's wife discovers in her desire the witchcraft of which her mother was convicted, complete the constellation.

2.7 The Clearing: World, Earth, and the Refusal of Etiology

In "The End of Philosophy and the Task of Thinking" (1964), Martin Heidegger glossed his *Lichtung*, the open in which beings come to presence, through the image of the forest clearing, insisting that the word derives from *lichten*, to make free and open, and is linguistically unrelated to *Licht*, brightness, though light may fall into a clearing. The farm in *The Witch* is a *Lichtung* in the most literal sense: an open wrested from the forest, in which the Puritan world appears. "The Origin of the Work of Art" (1935–36) described truth as the strife between *world*, the open context of a historical people's meanings, and *earth*, the self-secluding ground that sustains and resists it. *The Witch* stages that strife without metaphor. The world of scripture, covenant, and labor confronts the earth of the forest, which refuses it: the corn rots in the field, the traps take nothing, the beasts speak.

The rotting corn invites an etiological exit that the film conspicuously declines. Linnda Caporael (1976) proposed that the Salem afflictions were symptoms of ergotism, a poisoning by fungus-infected rye. *The Witch* places the blighted grain on screen and refuses to let it explain anything. Hierophantic realism forbids etiology: the earth's refusal is not a symptom but a speech. Eugene Thacker (2011) has argued that demonology is the premodern discourse in which thought confronted the "world-without-us," the world as indifferent or hostile to human meaning; the forest is that world, and the clearing is the frail, contested place where meaning holds it at bay. The second film will supply the other half of Heidegger's word. Where *The Witch* is a film of the clearing, *The Lighthouse* is a film of the light.

2.8 Levitation: Terminal Ecstasy I

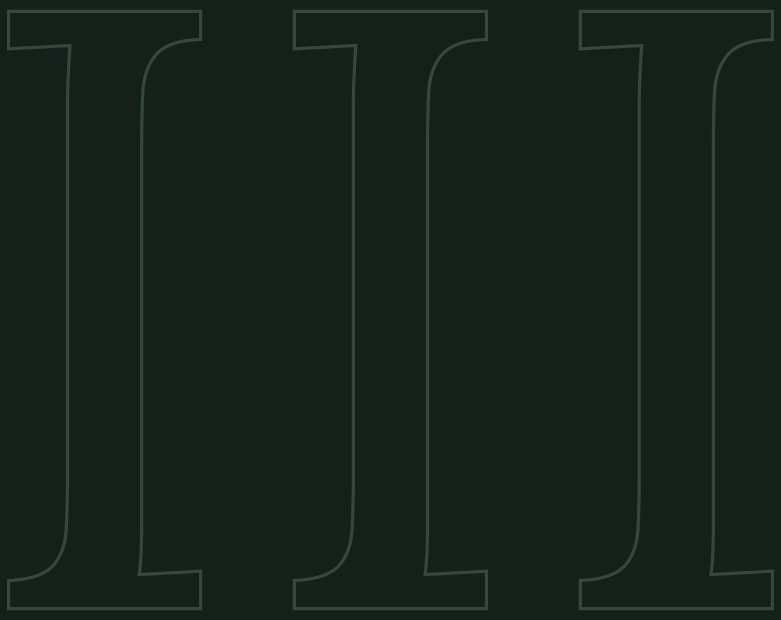
The final sabbat assembles the materials of a learned stereotype whose genealogy Carlo Ginzburg (1989) reconstructed as a compromise between clerical demonology and a substratum of Eurasian ecstatic belief: night flights, journeys of the soul, the battles of the Friulian *benandanti*. Margaret Murray's (1921) thesis of a surviving pagan witch-cult has long been discredited, and Ronald Hutton (2017) has reconstructed the witch as a global figure of fear rather than a historical religion; the film neither revives Murray nor illustrates Hutton but stages the sabbat as an ontological fact. Its details are archival. The hare that William and Caleb pursue recalls the Scottish confessions of Isobel Gowdie (1662), who recited the charm by which she went "intill ane haire, / With sorrow and sych and meikle caire."

Thomasin's ascent, naked and laughing above the fire, is the first terminal ecstasy of the corpus. It fulfills Eliade's shamanic "magical flight" and Otto's numinous at once: the *tremendum* of damnation and the *fascinans* of deliverance, inseparable in a single image. The laughter matters. It is neither the hysteric's convulsion nor the victim's scream but what Georges Bataille called sovereign laughter, the laughter of a being released from the servitude of utility; and it anticipates Hélène Cixous's (1975) laughing Medusa, the woman who, looked at straight on, is found to be neither deadly nor punished but laughing. Heaven and hell are rendered indistinguishable. The banished daughter has crossed the threshold that consumed her brother, and she has become its sovereign: the clearing abandoned for the forest, the covenant for the book, the ban converted into a vocation.

The Keeper and the Light

The Lighthouse

Set on the New England coast in the 1890s
Premiered 2019



The Lighthouse is a myth of modern labor in which the master's monopoly of enjoyment, the worker's theft of the sacred, and the Promethean ambition of the industrial subject are fused into a single rite of succession, and in which the light—at once commodity, Thing, and god—consumes the man who seizes it. Of the four films it is the most hermetic, the most allusive, and, as Chapter One argued, the only one that sustains Todorovian hesitation to its last frame, because it is set at the most disenchanted of Eggers's thresholds.

3.1 Sources and Sediments

The film's genealogy is layered. Its point of departure was an adaptation by Max Eggers, the director's brother and co-writer, of Edgar Allan Poe's "The Light-House," the diary of a solitary keeper left unfinished at Poe's death in 1849. Robert Eggers redirected the project toward a pair of keepers, drawing on the incident at the Smalls lighthouse off Pembrokeshire in 1801, where two keepers, both named Thomas, were isolated by storms; when one died, the survivor, fearing a charge of murder, lashed the corpse in a makeshift coffin outside the lantern room and was found, at relief, barely recognizable to those who knew him. The episode is traditionally credited with establishing the practice of three-man crews. To these sources the screenplay adds the coastal idiom of Sarah Orne Jewett's *The Country of the Pointed Firs* (1896), the oceanic rhetoric of Melville, and the moral cosmology of Coleridge's *Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (1798), in which the gratuitous killing of a seabird brings becalming, thirst, and a curse. Its imagery draws on fin-de-siècle Symbolism, notably Sascha Schneider's *Hypnose* (1904) and the Promethean iconography of the period, and it stands in a line of cinematic antecedents that includes Jean Grémillon's *Gardiens de phare* and Jean Epstein's *Finis Terrae* (both 1929).

The decade is chosen with structural precision. In 1893 Frederick Jackson Turner, citing the census of 1890, declared the American frontier closed; the sea became the last frontier, and the lighthouse its outermost fortification of reason. The U.S. Lighthouse Board, established in 1852, administered a federal bureaucracy of light whose central instrument was Augustin-Jean Fresnel's lens, which concentrated a lamp into a beam visible for miles. And in 1890 James George Frazer published the first edition of *The Golden Bough*. *The Lighthouse* is set in the decade in which the dying god became an object of science, and it places that god inside a federal installation.

3.2 Two Thomases: The Double and the Stolen Name

The Smalls supplied the film with its doubled name. The keeper is Thomas Wake; the young assistant who calls himself Ephraim Winslow confesses, late in the film, that he is Thomas Howard, and that he took the name of a timber-drive foreman whom he allowed to drown beneath the logs in the Canadian woods. Winslow therefore lives under a dead man's name: his symbolic identity is detached from his living body, so that he occupies, in Lacan's phrase, the zone "between two deaths." In Orlando Patterson's (1982) terms, he has inflicted social death upon himself through a voluntary natal alienation. The forest guilt that pursues him to sea links the film to its predecessor: the woods that devoured the Puritans' son return as the logs that drowned the foreman.

The doubling of the Thomases mobilizes the tradition Otto Rank (1914) traced and Freud (1919) theorized, in which the double, originally an insurance against death, becomes its uncanny harbinger. Its nearest literary precedent is again Poe. In "William Wilson" (1839), a man is pursued by a namesake whom he finally stabs, only to discover that he has murdered himself. *The Lighthouse* repeats the structure: the murder of Wake is the murder of the other Thomas, and it is followed by Winslow's own destruction. Ingmar Bergman's *Persona* (1966), with its two figures on an island whose faces finally merge, supplies the cinematic template. The film's unreliable chronology, in which neither man can say how long they have been on the rock or who did what, renders the two keepers less two persons than one subject divided between master and servant, father and son, superego and drive.

3.3 Lordship, Bondage, and the Sirens

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (1807) provides the film's social skeleton. The lord, having staked his life, enjoys the thing through the labor of the bondsman; the bondsman, in fear of death, the "absolute master," works upon the thing and, in forming it, forms himself; the lord's enjoyment proves dependent and stagnant, the truth of mastery servitude. Wake enjoys the light, ascending at night to stand naked before it; Winslow performs the thing-forming labor of hauling coal, whitewashing the tower, scrubbing the cistern, and emptying the chamber pots. Mastery is also writing. Wake keeps the logbook, in which he records the assistant's fate, recommending his dismissal without wages. The dialectic then reverses with a violence Hegel did not foresee. Winslow leashes Wake, walks him like a dog, and drives him into a grave. Alexandre Kojève's (1947) anthropological reading made the struggle for recognition the origin of the human; the film shows that the bondsman's victory yields not freedom but only the master's position, and that the master's position, which is the claim on the light, is lethal.

Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's first excursus in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/47) reads the Sirens episode of the *Odyssey* as the founding allegory of bourgeois labor. Odysseus, bound to the mast, hears the song but cannot act; his rowers, their ears stopped with wax, labor without hearing. Art becomes enjoyment rendered impotent, labor becomes deafness, and the division of the two is the price of self-preservation. Their thesis, *Schon der Mythos ist Aufklärung, und: Aufklärung schlägt in Mythologie zurück*, could stand as the film's epigraph. *The Lighthouse* retells the episode from the rowers' bench. Wake hears the song of the light in ecstatic privacy; Winslow is consigned to labor and forbidden it. Yet Winslow hears a siren anyway, the mermaid of his visions, and his hearing is his madness. The worker whose ears are unstopped can neither labor nor enjoy; he can only be consumed.

The master-servant pair has its modern dramatic form in Samuel Beckett. In *Waiting for Godot* (1953), Pozzo drives Lucky on a rope; in *Endgame* (1957), the blind, chair-bound Hamm commands Clov, who cannot sit, threatens daily to leave, and reports from the window on a dead grey sea. *The Lighthouse* is a Beckettian two-hander transposed into the mythic register, and its leash scene inverts Pozzo and Lucky. Its political economy, finally, is Marx's. In the section of *Capital* (1867) on the fetishism of commodities, Marx described how a definite social

relation among people assumes for them *die phantasmagorische Form eines Verhältnisses von Dingen*, the phantasmagoric form of a relation among things. The light appears to shine of itself; Wake's ritual adoration of it conceals the coal Winslow hauls. The lamp is the fetish-commodity of maritime capital, worshipped in the very act that hides the labor that feeds it.

3.4 The Priest of the Light: Nemi Transposed

Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* by asking who does not know Turner's picture of that name (1834), and then described the sacred grove of Diana at Nemi, where a priest-king, the *rex Nemorensis*, prowled by day and night with drawn sword around a certain tree. His successor could win office only by plucking a bough from the tree and slaying him in single combat, and, according to the ancient sources Frazer cited, the challenger had to be a runaway slave. Frazer borrowed Macaulay's verse for the institution: "The priest who slew the slayer, / And shall himself be slain."

The correspondence with *The Lighthouse* is exact and has gone unremarked. Wake is a priest-king guarding a sacred light he forbids his subordinate to approach. Winslow is a runaway, a fugitive under a false name, and a bondsman. Wake is aging and lame; his decline coincides with the sickening of the cosmos, the storm that strands them and the foul water of the cistern, as in Frazer's theory that the sacred king must be killed before his weakening contaminates the world. Winslow slays the priest and takes the key to the light, the bough that confers office, and is himself slain within minutes of his accession. *The Lighthouse* re-performs, as living rite, the myth that the decade of its setting was objectifying as "survival." It is Frazer staged from inside the grove.

3.5 Proteus and Prometheus

The film's two Titans are Proteus and Prometheus. In the fourth book of the *Odyssey*, Menelaus, becalmed on the island of Pharos off Egypt, learns from the sea-nymph Eidothea how to seize her father Proteus, the old man of the sea, and to hold him fast through his transformations—lion, serpent, leopard, boar, water, tree—until he yields a true prophecy. Virgil retold the capture in the fourth *Georgic*. The detail that unlocks the film is philological: Pharos, the island of Proteus, gave its name to the great lighthouse built there in the third century BC, and through it to the lighthouse in Greek, Latin, and the Romance languages (*pharus*, *phare*, *faro*). *The lighthouse is etymologically the island of Proteus.* Wake, whose stories of himself shift from scene to scene and who appears to Winslow as a tentacled sea-god, is Proteus; Winslow is Menelaus, wrestling the shape-shifter for a truth that, in this version, never comes.

Prometheus governs the ending. In Hesiod (*Theogony* 521–616) and in the tragedy attributed to Aeschylus, the Titan who stole fire for mortals is chained to a rock, and an eagle sent by Zeus devours his liver, which grows back each night. The final tableau of *The Lighthouse*, in which Winslow lies naked on the rocks while gulls tear at his entrails, is a Prometheus. The myth was modernity's favored self-image, from Goethe's defiant ode (1774) through Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) to Percy Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* (1820). Hans Blumenberg's *Work on Myth* (1979) made Prometheus the paradigm of the endless reworking through which European culture used myth to hold at bay what he called the "absolutism of reality," the overwhelming, unnamed pressure of a world not made for us. In *The Lighthouse*, the work on myth fails. The stories Wake tells, the shanties, the superstitions, the rules, all of them devices for distancing the absolutism of reality, collapse, and the sea, the storm, and the light arrive unmediated.

Georges Bataille supplies the final term. In "Rotten Sun" (1930) he observed that the sun, which signifies the highest elevation when it is not looked at, becomes, when stared at directly, an emblem of madness and horror; Icarus, who reached it, fell. In "The Solar Anus" (1931) he described a parodic cosmos in which the highest and the lowest are equivalent. Wake's body is that cosmos. His flatulence and his radiance, the grotesque lower stratum and the transcendent light, are the two poles of a single sacral body.

3.6 Apollo on the Rock: Tragedy and Satyr-Play

Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872) opposed the Apollonian—image, measure, and the *principium individuationis* Nietzsche took from Schopenhauer—to the Dionysian—intoxication, music, and the ecstatic dissolution of the individual into primordial unity. Phoebus Apollo is the god of light, and the lamp, the logbook, and the regulations are his. The liquor, the sea shanties, the drunken dancing, the storm, and the sexual frenzy are Dionysus's. The film's movement is the progressive inundation of the Apollonian by the Dionysian, culminating when Winslow faces the light itself and the Apollonian image becomes, as it does for Nietzsche's tragic hero, unbearable.

The film's dramaturgy is equally Attic. Aristotle (*Poetics* 1449a) credited Aeschylus with introducing the second actor; *The Lighthouse* is a tragedy for two actors. But the Athenian tetralogy ended with a satyr-play, in which Silenus and his chorus of drunken, priapic satyrs degraded the heroic matter of the preceding tragedies with obscene comedy. Wake's flatulence, the bawdy toasts, the scatology of the chamber pot belong to that genre. Mikhail Bakhtin's (1965) grotesque body, whose lower stratum degrades in order to renew, describes them. *The Lighthouse* fuses tragedy and satyr-play in a single work, and the fusion is the formal correlate of Bataille's solar anus: the sublime and the excremental are one body.

3.7 The Siren Divided: Mermaid and Gull

The only film of the corpus with no woman of flesh is saturated with the feminine. Winslow finds a scrimshaw mermaid hidden in his predecessor's mattress and masturbates over it; he glimpses a mermaid on the rocks, embraces her in a vision, and recoils from her shriek and her fish-sex. Creed's (1993) *vagina dentata* and the long misogynist iconography of the siren as devourer describe her. A further observation situates her historically. In Greek art the Sirens were bird-bodied women; only in the early medieval West, in texts such as the *Liber Monstrorum*, did they acquire the fish-tails of the modern mermaid. *The Lighthouse* divides the ancient siren into her two historical bodies. Her fish-half is the mermaid who calls Winslow toward the water; her bird-half is the gull, which sailors' belief holds to house the souls of drowned seamen.

Wake forbids harm to the gulls. Winslow, tormented by a one-eyed bird, beats it to death against the rocks, and the wind changes. The episode is Coleridge's albatross and Propp's violation of an interdiction, and it is also, in Descola's terms, the moment at which the naturalist worker discovers that he inhabits an animist world. The gull's single eye recalls Odin, who gave an eye for wisdom, and Bataille's obsessive ocular imagery; it watches, and it is avenged. Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936), in which a decaying New England port has interbred with creatures of the deep, supplies the horror of hybridity that Wake's tentacled epiphany and the mermaid embody—a horror whose racial anxieties Lovecraft's text exposes and Eggers's film, notably, does not share.

3.8 Licht and Gestell: The Light as Thing

If *The Witch* was the film of the *Lichtung* in Heidegger's sense, the open clearing, *The Lighthouse* is the film of the *Licht* he excluded from it. Its light is not the open but the concentrated, engineered beam of the Fresnel lens, an instance of what Heidegger, in "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), called *Gestell*: the enframing that reveals nature as standing-reserve, fire ordered and placed on call for commerce. Yet the film shows the *Gestell* remythologized. Wake worships the engineered light as a god. Technology does not dispel the numinous; it becomes its newest vessel.

Lacan's *das Ding* (Seminar VII, 1959–60) names the light's structural position. The Thing is the impossible object at the center of desire, approached only through substitutes, guarded by prohibition, fatal when reached; Antigone, who goes beyond the limit into the zone between two deaths, is its ethical heroine. The light is guarded by a father in the precise sense of Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913): the primal father who monopolizes enjoyment and is killed by the son who would possess it. Freud's "The Uncanny" quotes Schelling's definition: *unheimlich* is everything that ought to have remained secret and hidden but has come to light. *The Lighthouse* literalizes the definition. The hidden thing comes to light, and it is light.

3.9 Prometheus Devoured: Terminal Ecstasy II

The climax assembles every thread. Winslow buries Wake alive, in an episode that recalls Poe's "The Premature Burial" (1844), and kills him with an axe when he rises. He takes the key, climbs the spiral stair, the axis mundi of the rock, and opens the lens. His face convulses in a paroxysm in which agony and rapture cannot be distinguished; he falls. The final image is the Prometheus on the rocks. Terminal ecstasy here takes the form of anabasis followed by katabasis, ascent to the light and fall to the stone, and its valence is as undecidable as Thomasin's: Prometheus is punished, but Prometheus is a god.

The threshold-sovereign survives in this womanless world as fetish, siren, and hallucination, and her function is clarified by her bodily absence. It is the mermaid who calls Winslow beyond the human, toward the water and the light; it is the siren's bird-half that executes the sentence. The industrial subject, the runaway who would seize the fire of the order that exploits him, is consumed by the eagles of that order. But the eagles are gulls, and the gulls are the souls of the drowned. The Promethean modern self is devoured, at the last, by the dead.

The Thread and the Wound

The Northman

Set in the North Atlantic, AD 895 to the early tenth century
Released 2022

IV

The Northman is the political theology of the corpus. It returns the Hamlet legend to the pagan sacral kingship from which it emerged, exposes through a queen's speech the economy of slavery and rape on which the heroic ethic of vengeance rests, and then re-mythologizes that ethic in an apotheosis it neither endorses nor refuses. Its protagonist is the most complete figure of the ban in Eggers's work: prince, exile, wolf-warrior, self-branded slave, avenger, and finally one of the chosen dead.

4.1 From Saxo to Shakespeare and Back

The legend's earliest full form is in Books III and IV of Saxo Grammaticus's *Gesta Danorum* (c. 1200). Amlethus, son of Horwendillus and Gerutha, sees his father murdered by his uncle Fengo, who takes the widow and the realm. The boy survives by feigned idiocy, sitting by the hearth and whittling hooks; sent to Britain with a letter commanding his death, he rewrites it; returning, he fastens the drunken retainers beneath the hall's hangings with the hooks he had carved, burns the hall, and kills Fengo with an exchanged sword. Saxo's tale passed through François de Belleforest's *Histoires tragiques* (1570) and a lost English play, probably by Thomas Kyd, to Shakespeare's *Hamlet* (c. 1600), where revenge became interiority, delay, and doubt, and the father returned as a ghost from a Catholic Purgatory, as Stephen Greenblatt (2001) emphasized, in a Protestant play.

The operation performed by Eggers and his co-writer Sjón is a re-paganization. It strips away the Shakespearean psychology and the Christian afterlife and restores the legend to a Norse matrix rebuilt from the Eddas, the family sagas, Ibn Faḍlān's tenth-century account of the Rus', and the archaeology of the Viking Age, developed in consultation with specialists including the archaeologist Neil Price. Sjón brought to the collaboration a literary practice already steeped in Icelandic folk belief, from the mythic novella *The Blue Fox* (*Skugga-Baldur*, 2003) to his lyrics for Björk, who appears in the film as the Seeress, and his co-writing of Valdimar Jóhannsson's *Lamb* (2021). The names themselves are restored to their mythic weight. Saxo's Horwendillus is the Old Norse Aurvandill, whose frozen toe, Snorri Sturluson relates in *Skáldskaparmál*, Thor flung into the sky as a star; the Old English *Crist* hails the same figure, *Eala Earendel engla beorhtast*, in the line that would inspire Tolkien's Eärendil. The murdered king is the morning star. His murderer bears the name

Fjölnir, which is both one of Odin's names in *Grímnismál* and the name of the legendary Yngling king who, according to *Ynglinga saga*, drowned in a vat of mead. The usurper carries the god's name and a king's absurd death.

4.2 Dog-Rite and Wolf-Coat: The Männerbund

The film opens with an initiation. In an earthen chamber presided over by Willem Dafoe's Heimir the Fool, the returning king Aurvandill and the boy Amleth crawl on all fours, bark and howl, belch and break wind, inhale smoke, and receive a vision of the Tree of Kings before the son swears to avenge his father should he fall. The rite synthesizes a body of scholarship on the Germanic warrior band, or *Männerbund*: Kris Kershaw's *The One-Eyed God* (2000), which reconstructs an Indo-European institution of young warriors in canine and lupine guise under the patronage of the one-eyed god; Michael Speidel's history of Indo-European "mad warriors" (2002); and Price's *The Viking Way* (2002; 2nd ed. 2019), which reads Viking-Age warfare as saturated with ritual and sorcery. Behind them stands the founding and compromised thesis of Otto Höfler's *Kultische Geheimbünde der Germanen* (1934), whose ideological afterlife is addressed below.

The primary sources are unambiguous about the warrior's animal identity. Snorri's *Ynglinga saga* (ch. 6) describes Odin's men advancing without mail, mad as dogs or wolves, biting their shields, strong as bears or bulls. *Haraldskvæði*, composed around 900 by Þorbjörn hornklofi, places howling *berserkir* and wolf-coated *úlfhéðnar* in the ranks of Harald Fairhair, the very king whose rise, in the film, drives Fjölnir into exile. In *Völsunga saga* (ch. 8), Sigmund and his son Sinfjötli, living as outlaws in the forest, don wolf-skins and become wolves, a paternal initiation that is the closest mythic analogue to the film's opening. *Egils saga* gives the poet-warrior Egill a grandfather named Kveldúlfr, "Evening-Wolf," said to be a shape-shifter who grew savage at nightfall.

Mircea Eliade (1958) analyzed initiation as symbolic death and rebirth, in which the novice dies to childhood and passes through an animal or monstrous state before emerging transformed. The Norse paradigm is Odin's self-sacrifice in *Hávamál* (138): *Veit ek, at ek hekk vindga meiði á / nætr allar níu*—I know that I hung on the windy tree all nine nights, wounded by a spear, given to Odin, myself to myself. The dog-rite inducts Amleth into the Odinic order, and it inducts him into

the ban. Agamben (1995) recalled that Frankish law declared certain offenders *wargus*, wolf, expelled from the peace; the warrior band's lupine identity was the sanctioned form of the outlaw's status, a royal wolfishness. Amleth's itinerary unfolds the wolf's career in full: prince, exile, berserker, slave, avenger, and *einherji*.

4.3 Urðr: The Metaphysics of the Thread

The film's metaphysics is fate. The *Völuspá* (st. 20) describes the coming of the Norns from the water beneath the world-tree—*Þaðan koma meyjar margs vitandi*, thence come maidens much-knowing—who "laid down laws, chose lives" for the children of men, *þær lög lögðu, þær líf kuru*. The first is Urðr, "what has come to be," cognate with the Old English *wyrd*. The seeress who speaks the poem punctuates her vision with a refrain, *Vituð ér enn, eða hvat?*—would you know yet more, or what?—and Björk's Seeress inherits her office, binding Amleth's vengeance to a thread of fate and to a Maiden-King whose meaning he does not yet grasp. The film's seeresses descend from the literary *locus classicus* of the type, the *lítilvölva* Þorbjörg of *Eiríks saga rauða*, whose divination at a Greenland farmstead the saga describes in ethnographic detail.

The Witch and *The Northman* are twin studies of predestination. Calvin's decree and the Norns' weaving share a structure: the end is fixed, and freedom consists solely in the manner of meeting it. They differ in affect. The Calvinist is tormented by not knowing his fate; the Norse hero is told his fate and must consent to it. Nietzsche's formula for that consent, *Amor fati: das sei von nun an meine Liebe!* (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*, §276), describes Amleth's final choice. J. R. R. Tolkien's lecture "Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics" (1936) identified the distinctive Northern "theory of courage": gods and men side with order against chaos knowing they will lose at Ragnarök, so that defeat refutes nothing. Wagner's *Götterdämmerung* (1876) opens with the Norns weaving the rope of fate until it snaps, ending their knowledge and dooming the gods. Eggers's thread does not snap. It is fulfilled.

The philology of fate yields a final irony. Shakespeare's "weird sisters," whose name descends through Holinshed from *wyrd*, are Norns in English dress, and Akira Kurosawa's *Throne of Blood* (1957) restored them to their origins as a forest spirit at a spinning wheel. Mark Fisher (2016) defined the weird as "that which does not belong."

Etymologically, the weird is fate. *The Northman* is weird fiction in the archaic sense: a fiction of *wyrd*.

4.4 The Monstrous Double: Girard at the Gates of Hel

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) argued that vengeance is the paradigm of reciprocal, mimetic violence, which tends to escalate without limit because each retaliation imitates the act it answers. As the rivals mirror each other, the differences that structure the social order dissolve in a "sacrificial crisis," and the antagonists become "monstrous doubles." Only the unanimous violence of the community against a single scapegoat halts the escalation and founds order. In "Hamlet's Dull Revenge," collected in A *Theater of Envy* (1991), Girard read Shakespeare's play as the work of a dramatist exhausted by the revenge genre, whose hero's delay exposes the emptiness of the mimetic cycle.

Amleth does not delay. His is the undull revenge, restored to its archaic vigor, and the film follows it to Girard's conclusion without Girard's exit. The final duel at the Gates of Hel, set at the volcano Hekla, which medieval Christian writers from the twelfth century onward identified as a mouth of Hell, strips the antagonists of every difference: garments, rank, insignia, even the distinction between pagan Hel and Christian Hell. Two naked men in mirrored postures kill each other in fire. No scapegoat resolves the crisis, no order is founded, no community survives to remember. Walter Burkert's *Homo Necans* (1972), which located the origin of sacrifice in the guilt of the hunt and the community's bond in shared killing, describes the economy of the film's violence; Girard describes its terminus. The monstrous double is the last image of the vow.

4.5 Gudrún's Revelation: The Political Economy of Heroism

The vow is announced in the film's most quoted line—"I will avenge you, Father. I will save you, Mother. I will kill you, Fjölnir."—and the second clause is destroyed at the midpoint. Confronted by her son, Nicole Kidman's Gudrún laughs and tells him the truth: she was a slave taken in war by Aurvandill; Amleth was conceived in rape; she herself asked Fjölnir to kill the king and the boy. Then she kisses her son and proposes that they rule together. The heroic narrative of the paternal vow is revealed to rest on the violated body of the mother.

Three frames converge on the scene. The first is psychoanalytic. In his 1959 seminar on *Hamlet*, Jacques Lacan located the prince's paralysis not in an Oedipal wish but in his encounter with the desire of the mother, a desire unbounded by paternal law; Hamlet cannot act because he cannot answer the question of what she wants. Gudrún answers it aloud. Her desire was the father's death. The second frame is political-economic. The Viking-Age economy was an economy of slaves, from the Dublin market to the Volga trade Ibn Faḍlān observed, and the film's own plot depends on it: Amleth brands himself and boards a cargo of thralls bound for Iceland. Gudrún's speech performs what Horkheimer and Adorno called the enlightenment latent in myth. It disenchants the revenge saga from within by exposing its material basis.

The third frame is philological, and it is the decisive one. Carol J. Clover, whose *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) founded the modern theory of the slasher film, is also among the most important scholars of Old Norse literature, and her two fields meet in this scene. In "Hildigunnr's Lament" (1986), Clover analyzed the saga trope of the woman's *hvöt*, the whetting by which widows and mothers goad men to vengeance, as when Hildigunnr casts her murdered husband's bloody cloak over Flosi in *Njáls saga*. In "Regardless of Sex" (1993), she argued that the Norse sex-gender system turned less on anatomy than on the opposition between the *hvatr*, the vigorous, and the *blauðr*, the soft, so that a woman could occupy the position of power. Gudrún is the inciter inverted: she whetted not the son against the murderer but the murderer against the father, and she is *hvatr*. Her name is a saga code for exactly this sovereignty. It belongs to Guðrún Gjúkadóttir of the Eddic and Völsung tradition, who fed her husband Atli the hearts of their sons, and to Guðrún Ósvífrsdóttir of *Laxdæla saga*, who incited the killing of the man she loved and, asked in old age whom she had loved most, answered *Þeim var ek verst, er ek unna mest*—I was worst to him whom I loved most.

Gro Steinsland (1991) argued that Norse royal ideology rested on a sacred marriage between a god and a giantess, so that kings descended from the union of divine and chthonic powers and sovereignty passed through the female. Irish tradition knew the same structure in the goddess of Sovereignty, the hag at the well who, kissed by the rightful king, becomes beautiful and confers the realm, as in the tale of Niall of the Nine Hostages. Gudrún's kiss is the kiss of Sovereignty. She chose Fjölnir over Aurvandill, and she offers the kingdom to Amleth with her

mouth. She is the first fully articulated threshold-sovereign of the corpus who is not herself transformed: the woman who decides who will be king.

4.6 Olga of the Birch Forest: Seiðr and the Counter-Fate

Anya Taylor-Joy's Olga, a Slavic captive who practices herbal and lunar sorcery and spikes the farm's feast with intoxicating fungi, embodies the other feminine power of the North. Norse *seiðr* was coded feminine; when practiced by men it carried the stigma of *ergi*, unmanliness, an accusation Loki hurls at Odin himself in *Lokasenna* (st. 24). Price (2002) has reconstructed *seiðr* as a shamanic complex in which gender, sexuality, and the manipulation of minds were intertwined. Olga's magic works on minds rather than bodies, and it offers Amleth a counter-fate: escape, love, and children. Sailing away from Iceland, he sees her pregnant with twins and glimpses the Maiden-King of the prophecy; then he leaps into the sea to return and complete the vow, persuading himself that only Fjölnir's death will protect his line.

The device of the declined future has an exact contemporary parallel. In David Lowery's *The Green Knight* (2021), Gawain, at the Green Chapel, sees in a vision the life he would purchase by flight—kingship, a son lost in war, a realm in ruins—and returns to accept the blow. In both films the alternative of life is presented as a vision and refused, and in both the refusal is the hero's fidelity to the shape of his story. Both films also give their heroes a vulpine companion: Gawain's talking fox and the fox that shadows Amleth's Icelandic itinerary, readable as his *fylgja*, the attendant spirit whose appearance in the sagas often portends death. The Finnic analogue is Kullervo of the *Kalevala* (runos 31–36), born after his kin are massacred by his uncle Untamo, raised as a slave, returning to destroy his uncle's clan, and dying on his own sword, a slave-avenger whom Tolkien retold in *The Story of Kullervo* (written 1914–15) and transfigured as Túrin Turambar.

4.7 The Tree of Kings: Sacral Kingship and Its Desacralization

The Tree of Kings, the vision of a dynastic tree whose branches are the royal line, fuses Yggdrasil with genealogy, as the *Ynglingatal* fused the Swedish kings with their descent from Freyr. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) supplies its political theology. The king's natural body dies; his body politic, the *dignitas*, does not: *rex non moritur*. The Tree is the body politic made vegetal. Aurvandill's body falls, and the line continues through Amleth to the Maiden-King. Aurvandill himself, returning wounded and speaking of the time to yield to his son, is Frazer's aging sacred king, and his murder by his brother repeats the succession-by-slaying that *The Lighthouse* transposed to a federal light station.

The film's threshold of disenchantment is the transformation of sacral kingship. Harald Fairhair's unification of Norway in the late ninth century replaced local, sacral chieftaincies with territorial monarchy and drove dissident chieftains to settle Iceland, a commonwealth without a king, whose Alþingi was founded in 930 and which would accept Christianity there in 999 or 1000. Fjölnir in Iceland is a king demoted to a farmer, raising sheep in a kingless republic. Georges Dumézil's three functions—sovereignty, war, fertility—describe his fall: the usurper of the first function ends in the third. The rhyme with *The Witch* is exact. Both films begin with a banishment and settle an exiled patriarch on a frontier homestead, where the order he carried with him decays into the means of his destruction.

Nietzsche supplies the deepest paradox. In the *Genealogy of Morals* (I.11), he named "die skandinavischen Wikinger" among the exemplars of noble, master morality, whose strong natures discharge their resentment in immediate action and forget offenses. Amleth, the Viking, spends his life as a slave nursing a deferred revenge. He lives the master ethic in the form of what Nietzsche called slave morality, *ressentiment*. The film thus discloses, within the heroic code itself, the dependence of mastery on servitude that *The Lighthouse* discovered on a rock in the 1890s.

4.8 The Valkyrie and the Door-Frame: Terminal Ecstasy III

Dying at Hekla, Amleth sees a Valkyrie, *valkyrja*, "chooser of the slain," bear him on horseback through the sky toward Valhalla, the hall of the *einherjar* described in *Grímnismál* and Snorri's *Gylfaginning*, where the chosen dead fight each day and are restored each night. Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) read warrior societies as economies of glorious expenditure, in which sovereignty consists in squandering life; Valhalla is that economy made eternal, and Nietzsche's eternal recurrence realized as an afterlife.

Ibn Faḍlān's account of a Rus' chieftain's funeral on the Volga in 922 supplies the corpus's master image of the threshold. A slave girl who has volunteered to die with her master is lifted three times above a door-frame. The first time she says she sees her father and mother; the second, all her dead kin; the third, her master seated in Paradise, calling her. She is then intoxicated, violated by the men, and killed by an old woman whom the Rus' call the Angel of Death, and the ship is burned. The scene condenses everything *The Northman* knows about the feminine and the threshold. Women see over the door-frame: the Seeress, Olga in her visions, the Valkyrie. And the female body is the vehicle of the man's passage, as it will be again in *Nosferatu*. The Valkyrie is the threshold-sovereign of death in the strictest Schmittian sense: she decides who passes.

The ecstasy is sincere and indicted at once. Hierophantic realism presents Valhalla as real; Gudrún's speech has already exposed the ethic it rewards as founded on rape and slavery. The film holds both truths without resolving them, as *The Witch* held liberation and damnation in a single levitation.

4.9 The Hermeneutics of Danger

No film in the corpus is more exposed to misuse. Norse imagery has a long ideological afterlife, from the Germanic mysticism of the Third Reich, which drew on Höfler's *Männerbund* thesis, to contemporary white-supremacist appropriations of Odinism and runic symbols. Eggers's emic method, which refuses ironic distance from the worldview it depicts, is formally indistinguishable from celebration, and this is the hermeneutics of danger: the film's fidelity is both its truth and its vulnerability.

The film nonetheless builds the ban into its own myth. Gudrún's speech is an internal critique delivered at the narrative's center. The berserkers' massacre of a Slavic village, culminating in the burning of captives in a sealed building in a sequence that recalls Elem Klimov's *Come and See* (1985), is staged without glamour. Olga's counter-fate is given full weight before it is refused. *The Northman* neither celebrates nor condemns the heroic ethic; it re-possesses it. That is why it is dangerous, and why it is valuable. It renders visible, in their full seductive force, the archaic loyalties that a disenchanted modernity pretends to have outgrown, and it shows the price of each.

The Bride and the Plague

Nosferatu

Set in Wisborg, 1838
Released 2024



Nosferatu is the corpus's meditation on its own medium and the most explicit of its sacrifices: a revenant film about a revenant, set in the year photography first fixed a human figure, in which a bride who once summoned a demon must offer her body to close the threshold she opened. Where *The Witch* gave the sorceress her apotheosis, *Nosferatu* gives the hysteric hers, and the difference between the two endings is the difference between the forest and the town.

5.1 The Revenant Text

The film is the third return of a story that has never been permitted to die. Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) was adapted without authorization by Prana Film as *Nosferatu: eine Symphonie des Grauens* (1922), directed by F. W. Murnau from Henrik Galeen's screenplay and designed and produced by Albin Grau, an occultist who conceived the enterprise in esoteric terms. Florence Stoker sued; a German court ordered the prints destroyed; copies survived. The film thus outlived its own legal death and became, in the most literal sense, undead. Werner Herzog's *Nosferatu: Phantom der Nacht* (1979) returned it a second time, restoring Stoker's names and giving Klaus Kinski's vampire a melancholy longing for death. E. Elias Merhige's *Shadow of the Vampire* (2000) imagined that Murnau's lead actor, Max Schreck, really was a vampire, and cast Willem Dafoe in the role. Eggers's own career began, by his account, with a high-school stage production of Murnau's film, so that his *Nosferatu* closes a loop of a quarter-century: the filmmaker's origin returned as his culmination.

Eggers retains Murnau's coordinates—Wisborg, 1838, Thomas and Ellen Hutter, the agent Knock, the shipowner Harding, the town physician Sievers—and transforms Murnau's Professor Bulwer, a Paracelsian absorbed in carnivorous plants, whose name recalls the occult novelist Edward Bulwer-Lytton, into Professor Albin Eberhart von Franz. The new name is a double homage. Its first term salutes Albin Grau; its surname inescapably summons Marie-Louise von Franz, the Jungian analyst of fairy tales, alchemy, and the eternal youth. The remake is itself a revenant in Jacques Derrida's sense (1993): the figure that returns, whose every appearance is a reappearance, and whose inheritance obliges those who receive it.

5.2 1838: The Photographic Threshold and the Night-Side of Science

The year Murnau chose and Eggers kept is more resonant than either may have intended. In 1838 Louis Daguerre exposed his view of the Boulevard du Temple in Paris, in which the long exposure erased all moving traffic and preserved only a man standing still to have his boots polished: the first photograph to fix a human figure. *Nosferatu* is set in the year the mechanical image first captured a person. André Bazin's "Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) traced the plastic arts to a "mummy complex," the impulse to embalm the dead against time, and found in photography its fulfillment. A film about a preserved corpse set in photography's year zero is a film about its own medium. Orlok, whose shadow-hand passes over the roofs of Wisborg as Murnau's shadow climbed the stair, is cinema's daemon; his destruction by light figures the nitrate strip consumed by the lamp that projects it.

The year is also the heart of the Biedermeier, the period of domestic retreat between the Congress of Vienna and the revolutions of 1848, and of German Romantic medicine. Gotthilf Heinrich von Schubert's *Ansichten von der Nachtseite der Naturwissenschaft* (1808) had made the "night-side" of nature—dreams, somnambulism, animal magnetism, clairvoyance—a legitimate object of science, extending the animal magnetism of Franz Anton Mesmer and the *Naturphilosophie* of Schelling. Justinus Kerner's *Die Seherin von Prevorst* (1829), the case history of Friederike Hauffe, a wasting, magnetically treated somnambulist who conversed with spirits, was among the most widely read medical books of the age. Ellen Hutter is a Seeress of Prevorst: somnambulist, clairvoyant, wasting, spirit-afflicted. The contest between Dr. Sievers, who bleeds, sedates, and corsets her, and von Franz, who reads her case through Paracelsus and Agrippa as a spiritual one, re-enacts the struggle of the 1830s between academic medicine and Romantic natural philosophy; in Descola's terms, between naturalism and analogism. Analogism wins.

The men call Ellen hysterical and melancholic. The diagnosis is anachronistic in its precision, for hysteria's great clinical age—Charcot's Salpêtrière, Breuer and Freud's *Studies on Hysteria* (1895)—lay decades ahead, and its anachronism is pointed. Benjamin Christensen's *Häxan* (1922) argued that the witches of the past were the hysterics of the present, misrecognized by a superstitious age. Eggers reverses

Christensen: the hysteric of the present is the witch, a summoner of the dead, misrecognized by a rationalist age.

5.3 The Inverted Annunciation

The prologue shows the adolescent Ellen, lonely and grieving, calling into the night for a guardian, an angel, any spirit that will comfort her. Something answers, and she is seized in a convulsion indistinguishable from rapture. The scene is an inverted Annunciation. In Luke, the angel comes unbidden to the virgin and receives her consent: "Be it unto me according to thy word" (1:38). In *Nosferatu*, the virgin calls, and the answer is a revenant; her prayer is the fiat, and it is a summons. Rainer Maria Rilke had written the theology of that answer in the first of the *Duineser Elegien* (1923): *Ein jeder Engel ist schrecklich*, every angel is terrible, for beauty is nothing but the beginning of terror. Ellen asked for an angel.

In Charles Taylor's terms, Ellen is the only porous self in Wisborg. Her husband, the Hardings, and the physician are buffered, and their buffering is their vulnerability: they cannot perceive what threatens them because they do not believe it can. *The Witch* showed Puritan disenchantment as disarmament; *Nosferatu* shows bourgeois disenchantment as blindness. Ellen's melancholy has its own genealogy. Robert Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621) catalogued its religious and erotic forms; Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) defined the melancholic as one who has lost an object without knowing what was lost; Julia Kristeva's *Black Sun* (1987), taking its title from Gérard de Nerval's "le Soleil noir de la Mélancolie" (1854), located melancholy in the mourning of an archaic Thing that preceded every object. Orlok is Ellen's Thing, as the light was Winslow's, and her black sun is the inverse of his lamp.

5.4 The Count and the Contract: Feudal Revenant, Bourgeois Property

The vampire enters the bourgeois town through the property market. Knock, an occultist secretly in Orlok's service, sends Hutter to the Carpathians to sell the Count a derelict house facing Hutter's own; Hutter signs a contract in a script he cannot read, whose terms, it emerges, bear upon Ellen herself. Marx had supplied the governing figure in *Capital* (1867): "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks." Franco Moretti's "The Dialectic of Fear" (1982) read Stoker's Count as monopoly capital, a drive to accumulate that must expand or die.

Eggers's Orlok is more feudal than capitalist, and here Kantorowicz returns. His natural body has rotted—Eggers made him a visibly decomposing Transylvanian noble with a hussar's moustache—but his title, his claim, and his *dignitas* persist. *Rex non moritur* becomes a horror: the Count never dies. His claim upon Ellen is a spectral *droit du seigneur*, the feudal lord's alleged right of the first night over a vassal's bride, which Alain Boureau (1995) showed to be largely a legal myth—a fantasy of feudal prerogative that survived as fantasy long after the feudal order. Orlok is that myth, returning to claim what it never lawfully possessed.

He is also the folk revenant. Paul Barber (1988) showed that the vampire of Balkan and Slavic folklore was not an aristocrat but a bloated peasant corpse, identified by exhumation; Montague Summers (1928) compiled the lore. Emily Gerard's "Transylvanian Superstitions" (1885), Stoker's source, described the Scholomance, a school in the mountains where the Devil trained scholars in black magic. Eggers's Orlok fuses all three: folk corpse, feudal count, dead sorcerer. Agnes Murgoci's "The Vampire in Roumania" (1926) recorded the Romanian distinction between the *strigoi mort*, the dead revenant, and the *strigoi viu*, the living witch whose soul leaves the body at night to consort with the dead. The distinction unlocks the film. Orlok is a *strigoi mort*; Ellen, whose nocturnal seizures carry her soul toward him, is a *strigoi viu*. The bride is not merely the vampire's victim but his living counterpart.

5.5 Plague, Exception, and the Collapse of the Buffered Town

Orlok arrives by ship with rats, and the rats bring plague. Murnau introduced the pestilence, absent from Stoker, in a Germany emerging from war and the influenza of 1918; Siegfried Kracauer (1947) read his Orlok as a tyrant-figure in the procession of Weimar monsters, and Lotte Eisner (1952) as the culmination of the haunted screen. Eggers released his film in December 2024, after a pandemic that had made quarantine, mass burial, and the closing of cities contemporary experience. The film's plague is not an allegory of disease but a dissolution of the social order. Antonin Artaud's "The Theatre and the Plague" (1933) described the plague as a delirium that abolishes social forms and releases a latent cruelty; Girard's "The Plague in Literature and Myth" (1974) read it as the image of the sacrificial crisis, the collapse of differences that precedes the search for a scapegoat. Wisborg undergoes both. The Harding household, the very model of Biedermeier prosperity and rationalist confidence, is annihilated.

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens with the sentence *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*: sovereign is he who decides on the exception. In plague the normal order is suspended, and Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) asks who decides in that suspension. In Wisborg no magistrate, physician, or husband decides. The decision falls to Ellen.

5.6 The Maiden Pure in Heart: Sacrifice, Erotism, Liebestod

Murnau's intertitles cite a book of vampires according to which the spell can be broken only by a woman pure in heart who offers her blood freely to the vampire and keeps him at her side past the first cock-crow. Eggers preserves the rite and darkens it. Ellen sends her husband away, admits Orlok across the threshold of her chamber—in Murnau, through an opened window—gives herself, and holds him through the night until the sun destroys him and she dies.

The ending is a sacrifice and a consummation at once. Georges Bataille's *Erotism* (1957) defined eroticism as the affirmation of life even unto death, the longing of discontinuous beings for a continuity that only death fully grants, and located the sacred in the transgression of taboo. Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) described the fusion of Eros with a drive toward death. Wagner's *Tristan und Isolde* (1865)

gave the fusion its Romantic form: the lovers, *Nachtgeweihte*, consecrated to night, invoke it in the second act (*O sink hernieder, Nacht der Liebe*), curse the day that separates them, and find union only in the *Liebestod*. Orlok dies of day; Ellen and her demon are Tristan and Isolde destroyed by *Tag*. Behind Wagner stand Novalis's *Hymnen an die Nacht* (1800), in which night is the sacred realm of love and the beloved's grave the site of mystical union, and Goethe's "Die Braut von Korinth" (1797), in which a dead bride, kept from her betrothed by her Christian mother's vow, returns to drink his heart's blood. Eggers inverts Goethe's genders: the bride lives, the bridegroom is dead. Sheridan Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872) had already made the vampire the object of a woman's desire.

The theology is Eucharistic and inverted. The vampire's drinking parodies the cup of the new covenant (Matt. 26:28), but here the woman gives her blood, and her blood redeems the town. Orlok feeds at her breast. The image completes a motif the corpus has carried since its first film: Katherine nursing the raven that tears her. In both films the breast is an altar, and the flow of the maternal economy is reversed, from nourishment to sacrifice.

5.7 The White Horse and the Ethics of the Folk

On his journey Hutter witnesses Romani villagers lead a white horse, ridden by a naked girl, across a graveyard until it balks at a grave, which they open to stake the revenant within. The rite reproduces a practice recorded in Romanian folklore, in which a horse that refuses to step over a grave reveals the vampire beneath. The Gothic tradition has a long and ugly habit of making the Roma the vampire's servants, as Stoker's Szgany serve Dracula. Eggers's emic method reverses the valence: the Romani villagers are the only community in the film that knows what to do, the only one that retains protective magic. They possess what the banished Puritans of *The Witch* lacked and what the buffered burghers of Wisborg have forgotten. The scene does not escape the exoticizing frame of its genre, but it relocates knowledge from the town to the margin, as the corpus always does.

5.8 Dawn: Terminal Ecstasy IV

The final tableau—the vampire dead upon the bride, the two bodies entwined in the gray light—completes the fourth terminal ecstasy of the corpus. Bataille's rotten sun returns as dawn. Ellen's ecstasy is erotic, sacrificial, and fatal, and it is the act of a sovereign: she opened the threshold as a girl by her prayer, and she closes it as a woman with her body. Her decision is the exception that saves a town that had pathologized her.

The ending is double, as *The Witch*'s was. It emancipates a desire that the bourgeois order denied and conscripts that desire into the order's preservation. Catherine Clément, in "The Guilty One" (in *The Newly Born Woman*, with Hélène Cixous, 1975), argued that the sorceress and the hysteric were the two historical figures through which feminine revolt was both expressed and contained: their contestation was real, and it was reabsorbed into the symbolic order it contested. Eggers's first and fourth features stage Clément's diptych. Thomasin is the sorceress, who escapes into the forest and becomes the order's nightmare; Ellen is the hysteric, whose revolt is converted into the sacrifice that conserves the town. Between them lies the whole range of the threshold-sovereign's fate. And the light that destroys Orlok is, at the last, the light of cinema itself: the medium that preserves the dead is the medium that burns them.

The Eggersian Constellation

Comparative Mythopoetics

Folk horror, the vampire, the witch, and the North

VI

Set among its generic kin, Eggers's cinema is distinguished by a single structural refusal: it never sends a modern surrogate into the archaic world. This chapter names that refusal *endogeneity*, traces it through six comparative series—folk horror, the predestinarian cinema of his contemporaries, the cinema of isolation, Northern mythological fiction, and the vampire and witch traditions, with their literary hinterland—and argues that it aligns Eggers less with the folk-horror revival than with a minority lineage of the art cinema of the sacred.

6.1 Exogenous and Endogenous Folk Horror

Adam Scovell's (2017) "folk horror chain"—landscape, isolation, skewed belief systems, and a culminating happening or summoning—describes a genre whose British canon was fixed by the trio Mark Gatiss called the "unholy trinity": Michael Reeves's *Witchfinder General* (1968), Piers Haggard's *The Blood on Satan's Claw* (1971), and Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* (1973). The genre's dominant form is what this dissertation calls *exogenous*: a modern or modernized subject crosses into an archaic enclave and serves as the spectator's surrogate, ethnographer, and victim. In *The Wicker Man*, Sergeant Howie—a Christian virgin and an officer of the law—enters Summerisle and is burned in the giant wicker effigy that Caesar attributed to the Gauls (*De Bello Gallico* 6.16), a sacrifice choreographed from Frazer. The film's most acute irony is that Summerisle's paganism is itself an Enlightenment product: Lord Summerisle's grandfather, a Victorian agronomist, revived the old gods to make his tenants work. Myth is already enlightenment, as Horkheimer and Adorno insisted, and here enlightenment reverts to mythology for the sake of crop yields. The exogenous pattern recurs in Ari Aster's *Midsommar* (2019), whose visitors to the Hårga are literally anthropology students quarreling over a thesis topic; in Gareth Evans's *Apostle* (2018), whose protagonist infiltrates an island cult in 1905; in David Bruckner's *The Ritual* (2017), whose British hikers stumble upon the cult of a Scandinavian *jötunn*; and in Ben Wheatley's *Kill List* (2011).

Eggers's films are *endogenous*: they present the archaic cosmos from within, with no modern proxy. The distinction is not a matter of plot alone. In exogenous folk horror, the spectator's modernity is represented on screen and thereby protected: it can be identified with, judged, pitied, or sacrificed in effigy. In endogenous folk horror, the spectator's modernity has no proxy, and the spectator is therefore the only outsider present. The absence of a surrogate is the formal

condition of ontological re-possession. Eggers's endogenous lineage is a minority tradition of international art cinema: Dreyer's *Day of Wrath* (1943); Kaneto Shindō's *Onibaba* (1964), in which two women in fourteenth-century Japan survive by murdering samurai until a demon mask fuses to a face, the ban made flesh, and his *Kuroneko* (1968); František Vláčil's *Marketa Lazarová* (1967), a thirteenth-century Bohemian epic of pagan robber-knights, Christian kingship, and wolves; and the pagan Kupala night of Andrei Tarkovsky's *Andrei Rublev* (1966). Its recent heirs, Lukas Feigelfeld's *Hagazussa* (2017), set among fifteenth-century Alpine goatherds, and Goran Stolevski's *You Won't Be Alone* (2022), set in nineteenth-century Macedonia, are witch films made in Eggers's wake, and both are endogenous.

A borderline case clarifies the principle. Aleksei German's *Hard to Be a God* (2013) immerses the spectator in a medieval world of mud, excrement, and cruelty as totally as any Eggers film, yet its premise is exogenous: its protagonist is a scientist from Earth observing a planet stranded in its Middle Ages. The texture is endogenous; the frame is ethnographic. German's film becomes a parable of exogeneity's failure, its observer gradually indistinguishable from what he observes. Eggers dispenses with the observer from the start.

6.2 The Predestinarian Cinema: Aster, Glass, and Eggers

Eggers is routinely paired with Ari Aster, whose *Hereditary* (2018) and *Midsommar*, like *The Witch*, were distributed by A24 and end in inverted coronations. In *Hereditary*, a family discovers that it has been predestined across generations to furnish a body for King Paimon, a demon of the seventeenth-century *Ars Goetia*; the son is crowned in a treehouse before kneeling cultists. In *Midsommar*, Dani is crowned May Queen and smiles as her boyfriend burns. Both directors stage fatalism, and both end in apotheosis. Their difference is decisive. Aster's fatalism is psychological and familial: the occult figures the intergenerational transmission of trauma, grief, and mental illness, and his cults are therapeutic communities that absorb a grieving subject. Eggers's fatalism is cosmological: fate is a structure of the world, whether decree, *urðr*, or contract. Aster's protagonists are buffered modern selves whose buffers fail under grief; Eggers's are porous selves in porous worlds. Aster stages the possession of the self; Eggers stages the possession of the spectator. The endings mark the difference with precision. Dani's smile is that of an individual dissolved into Turnerian *communitas*; Thomasin's laugh is that of a sovereign.

Rose Glass's *Saint Maud* (2019), also distributed by A24, supplies the counter-example that defines Eggers's method negatively. Its pious, ecstatic nurse sets herself alight on a beach, and for a moment the film shows her as she sees herself, transfigured and winged in light. Then a single cut reveals her from outside, screaming as she burns before horrified onlookers. That cut is the etic correction of the emic vision, the Todorovian exit into the explained. It is the cut Eggers never makes. His films end on the emic image—the levitation, the Valkyrie, the dawn on the entwined bodies—and leave the spectator no outside from which to correct it.

6.3 The Cinema of Isolation: Kubrick, Bergman, Polanski

The Lighthouse belongs to a cinema of confinement whose canonical modern instance is Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980). The parallels are structural: a caretaker isolated in a building at once sacred and cursed; a predecessor who went mad (Grady, in Kubrick; in Eggers, the former assistant whose madness Wake recounts); an axe; a dissolution of time. Kubrick's final revelation that Jack Torrance has "always been the caretaker," photographed among the revelers of a 1921 ball, is a Frazerian succession rendered as eternal recurrence: the Overlook, like Nemi, has always had its priest. The difference is endogeneity. Kubrick sends a 1970s family into the haunted hotel; Eggers sends no one, and the 1890s are not a destination but the world.

Roman Polanski's *Cul-de-sac* (1966), set in a castle on the tidal island of Lindisfarne, and Bergman's *Persona* (1966) and *Hour of the Wolf* (1968), both set on islands where identities fuse and demons gather, complete *The Lighthouse*'s cinematic genealogy alongside the silent maritime cinema of Grémillon and Epstein. Bergman is the nearest. *Hour of the Wolf*, to which the Conclusion returns, isolates a painter and his wife on a remote island, where the wife comes to see the demons that possess her husband before he vanishes into the forest. It is a Bergman film with the architecture of an Eggers film: island, possession, a woman who sees across, a forest that takes.

6.4 Northern Fatalism and the Mythological Epic

The Northman enters a crowded field of Northern mythological fiction, and its distinctiveness is again density against abstraction and sincerity against irony. Nicolas Winding Refn's *Valhalla Rising* (2009) follows a mute, one-eyed slave-warrior, an Odin in all but name, among Christian crusaders to a new world that may be Hell; it evacuates the myth into pure form, landscape, and silence. Eggers does the opposite, saturating every frame with material culture, ritual speech, and named gods. John Milius's *Conan the Barbarian* (1982), which opens with Nietzsche's dictum that what does not kill us makes us stronger, shares *The Northman*'s plot skeleton—a child who witnesses his parents' murder, enslavement, a body forged in servitude, and revenge on the killer-king—but it is a fantasy of strength without metaphysics. *The Northman* supplies the metaphysics: Norns, Valkyrie, and the theory of courage.

Robert Zemeckis's *Beowulf* (2007), scripted by Neil Gaiman and Roger Avary, offers the closest analogue to Gudrún. In this revision of the Old English poem, Grendel is Hrothgar's son by Grendel's mother, Beowulf fathers the dragon upon her, and every king's sovereignty is founded on a secret union with a monstrous mother who bears his doom: Steinsland's giantess-sovereignty transposed into Hollywood fantasy. John Gardner's *Grendel* (1971), narrated by the monster, mocks the Shaper, the court poet who manufactures heroic myth from rapine; its Grendel performs from outside the hall the demystification Gudrún performs from within. Cormac McCarthy's *Blood Meridian* (1985), whose Judge Holden preaches that war is god, describes a world in which violence is the only theology; the berserker raid on the Slavic village is its Viking-Age equivalent. Tolkien's Túrin and Kullervo, Wagner's Norns, Kurosawa's spinning spirit, and Lowery's Green Knight, examined in Chapter Four, complete the field. Within it, *The Northman* is unique in combining the epic's scale with the endogenous camera of the art film.

Vláčil's *Marketa Lazarová* deserves particular emphasis, for it shares the chronotope of *Werwulf*. Set in thirteenth-century Bohemia at the friction point between clan paganism and Christian royal power, populated by wolves that devour the weak and by men who live like them, it is the most exact cinematic anticipation of the world the forthcoming film has announced.

6.5 The Vampire Lineage and the Relocation of Desire

The literary vampire began as an aristocratic seducer. John Polidori's *The Vampyre* (1819), modeled on Byron, made Lord Ruthven the type; Sheridan Le Fanu's *Carmilla* (1872) made the vampire the object of a woman's desire; Stoker fused aristocrat, invader, and seducer. Cinema then oscillated between de-eroticized monster and romantic lover. Murnau's rat-like Orlok and Dreyer's *Vampyr* (1932)—whose vampire is an old woman and whose hero watches his own burial from inside the coffin, as Wake is buried in *The Lighthouse*—stand at one pole; Terence Fisher's Hammer *Dracula* (1958) and Francis Ford Coppola's *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (1992), whose Count crosses oceans of time for a reincarnated love, stand at the other. Herzog's melancholic Count (1979), Anne Rice's confessional vampires (1976), and Jim Jarmusch's aesthete lovers in *Only Lovers Left Alive* (2013) gave the vampire an interiority. George A. Romero's *Martin* (1977) took the Todorovian exit, leaving open whether its vampire is a delusion.

Nina Auerbach (1995) observed that every age embraces the vampire it needs. Eggers's age received a vampire without interiority: a rotting feudal claim and a plague, neither lover nor outsider nor allegory. Yet the film is intensely erotic, because it relocates the tradition's erotic agency from the predator to the summoner. The desire in Eggers's *Nosferatu* is Ellen's. The relocation is anchored in the oldest rule of the lore. Stoker's Van Helsing explains that the vampire may not enter a dwelling at first unless someone of the household bids him come, and Tomas Alfredson's *Let the Right One In* (2008) made the rule literal, its child vampire bleeding when she crosses a threshold uninvited. The vampire is the only monster whose entry depends upon a sovereign decision by the keeper of the threshold. That is why the vampire film is the natural culmination of a corpus organized around the threshold-sovereign.

6.6 The Witch Lineage and Its Three Exits

The cinematic witch has had three exits from Todorovian hesitation. The first is rationalist: Christensen's *Häxan* (1922) explained the witch as a misdiagnosed hysteric. The second is political: *Witchfinder General*, Ken Russell's *The Devils* (1971), drawn from Aldous Huxley's account of the Loudun possessions of 1634, and Arthur Miller's *The Crucible* (1953) make the witch a victim and the witch-hunter the monster, the persecution an allegory of political terror. The third is supernatural and sovereign: the witch is real and powerful. Dario Argento's *Suspiria* (1977) and Luca Guadagnino's *Suspiria* (2018) belong here, and the latter offers Thomasin's closest sibling. Its heroine, Susie Bannion, raised in a rigorist Mennonite household in Ohio, joins a Berlin dance academy run by a coven and is revealed as Mother Suspiriorum herself, a sovereign witch who grants death to those who ask for it. A girl from a severe Protestant sect becomes the sovereign of the coven: the structure of *The Witch*, transposed to 1977. Valdimar Jóhannsson's *Lamb* (2021), co-written by Sjón, belongs to the same family. An Icelandic couple raises a lamb-headed child until its ram-headed father returns from the wild to reclaim it, a Black Phillip asserting the sovereignty of the wilderness over the household.

Eggers's hierophantic realism belongs to the third exit and refuses its consolations. His witch is real, but her reality offers neither the political comfort of the second exit, which assures us that only the persecutors were monstrous, nor the triumphalism that sometimes attends the

third, which makes the coven a utopia. *The Witch* insists that the persecutors' fears were true and that the persecuted girl's liberation is real. That coincidence is the ban's logic, and no other film in the lineage holds it so steadily.

6.7 Literary Mythopoeia

The literary tradition behind Eggers is the Anglo-American weird tale in its premodernist phase. Hawthorne, Machen, Coleridge, Poe, and Lovecraft have been discussed in the preceding chapters. Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907) and "The Wendigo" (1910) located the numinous in wilderness itself; in the latter, a guide is seized by a spirit of the northern forest and carried off at such speed that his feet burn. It is a terminal ecstasy in the form of an abduction. M. R. James's "Oh, Whistle, and I'll Come to You, My Lad" (1904) supplies the emblem of summoning by utterance: an antiquarian finds a bronze whistle inscribed *Quis est iste qui venit*—who is this who is coming?—blows it, and calls something to him. It is *lupus in fabula* in the form of a ghost story, and Eggers's archival speech is that whistle.

Lovecraft opened "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1927) by declaring fear the oldest and strongest of human emotions, and fear of the unknown the oldest and strongest kind of fear. Eggers revises the axiom. His horror is not fear of the unknown but fear of the formerly known: the cosmos our ancestors knew too well, which modernity unlearned, and which returns.

6.8 The Specific Difference

The comparative series converge on a single profile. Eggers's specific difference lies in five features that no other filmmaker in these traditions combines: endogeneity, the absence of a modern surrogate; ontological sincerity, the refusal of every rationalist, political, or ironic exit; material density, the saturation of the image with verifiable culture; structural constancy, the recurrence of a single rite across a millennium of settings; and the centrality of the threshold-sovereign. He has converted the minority tradition of Dreyer, Vláčil, Shindō, and Tarkovsky into genre cinema without surrendering its seriousness, and in doing so has made the art cinema of the sacred available to the multiplex as an experience of horror. The next chapter asks what that experience is, and what it reveals.

Lycanthropology

An Original Synthesis

Six invariants and a prediction

VII

The four films constitute a single argument. Read in the order of their settings rather than their release, they narrate the successive bans through which Western modernity constituted its subject, and they narrate them from the side of the banned. This chapter reconstructs that counter-genealogy, formalizes the apparatus that generates each film, develops its invariants into a theory, defends the theory against its two most tempting misreadings, and exposes it to refutation by the film about to arrive.

7.1 The Diegetic Chronology: A Counter-Genealogy of Disenchantment

In production order the corpus moves from New England (2015, 2019) to the North Atlantic (2022) to Germany (2024). In diegetic order it describes a different trajectory: the North Atlantic around 900 (*The Northman*), England in the thirteenth century (*Werwulf*, forthcoming), New England around 1630 (*The Witch*), Wisborg in 1838 (*Nosferatu*), and the New England coast in the 1890s (*The Lighthouse*). Reordered so, the films occupy five stations of Western rationalization, each with its disenchanting order and its characteristic ban. Around 900, sacral kingship yields to territorial monarchy and a political economy of slaves, and the ban takes the form of outlawry, exile, and enslavement. In the thirteenth century, as section 7.9 argues, the law rationalizes itself and produces the outlaw as wolf. Around 1630, Calvinism completes the elimination of magic, and the ban is banishment from the godly commonwealth. In 1838, scientific medicine, bourgeois property, and the mechanical image advance together, and the ban becomes diagnosis and quarantine. In the 1890s, a federal bureaucracy of light, the wage contract, and the closing of the frontier reduce the ban to anonymous labor on the outermost rock.

The sequence is a genealogy in the sense Michel Foucault drew from Nietzsche (1971): not a search for origins but a record of descent (*Herkunft*) and emergence (*Entstehung*), attentive to the accidents and the dominations that a unified history conceals. Eggers's chronology fragments Weber's grand narrative of disenchantment into a series of local emergences, each a scene of domination, and each producing its own remainder.

Its decisive finding is that every threshold of disenchantment is a site of re-enchantment. Bruno Latour's *We Have Never Been Modern* (1991) argued that the "modern Constitution" proceeds by

purification—separating nature from society, human from nonhuman, things from signs—while its practice proliferates hybrids by translation, so that the more thoroughly the moderns purify, the more hybrids multiply unseen. Eggers's monsters are Latour's hybrids made visible: goat and devil; woman, fish, and bird; man and wolf; the living and the dead. Jason Ā. Josephson-Storm's *The Myth of Disenchantment* (2017) showed that disenchantment never occurred as a completed process, that the founders of the human sciences were themselves immersed in occult and spiritualist currents, and that the story of disenchantment is itself a myth. Eggers's corpus is the cinematic demonstration of the same thesis, in the very form Horkheimer and Adorno foresaw: enlightenment reverting to mythology at each stage of its advance.

7.2 The Lycanthropic Dispositif

Agamben (2006), extending Foucault, defines an apparatus, or *dispositif*, as anything capable of capturing, orienting, determining, or controlling the gestures, behaviors, opinions, and discourses of living beings. The recurrence of one structure across four films set a millennium apart indicates that they are generated by such an apparatus. This dissertation calls it the *lycanthropic dispositif* and formalizes it in six invariants: (I) a threshold of disenchantment, which fixes the historical location; (II) a ban, which constitutes the protagonist by exclusion; (III) an initiation without return, in which separation opens a liminal interval lived between two deaths and reaggregation is displaced into the numinous; (IV) an anomalous mediator, the animal that conducts the passage; (V) a threshold-sovereign, the feminine figure who decides on the exception between orders of being; and (VI) a terminal ecstasy, the consummation by light, fire, or air. The table sets five of the invariants across the four completed films, ordered by diegetic chronology.

Film (setting)	I. Threshold of disenchantment	II. Ban	IV. Anomalous mediator	V. Threshold-sovereign	VI. Terminal ecstasy
The Northman (c. 895–914, North Atlantic)	Sacral kingship yields to territorial monarchy and a slave economy	Exile, berserker outlawry, self-enslavement	Wolf; raven; fox (*fylgja*)	Gudrún; Olga; the Seeress; the Valkyrie	Mutual killing at Hekla; ascent to Valhalla
The Witch (c. 1630, New England)	Calvinist elimination of magic	Banishment from the plantation	Black Phillip; hare; raven	The witch; Thomasin, becoming sovereign	Levitation above the sabbat fire

Film (setting)	I. Threshold of disenchantment	II. Ban	IV. Anomalous mediator	V. Threshold-sovereign	VI. Terminal ecstasy
Nosferatu (1838, Wisborg)	Scientific medicine, bourgeois property, the mechanical image	Diagnosis, confinement, plague quarantine	Rats; white horse	Ellen	Sacrificial *Liebestod* at dawn
The Lighthouse (1890s, New England coast)	Federal bureaucracy, wage labor, the Fresnel lens	Fugitive under a dead man's name	Gulls; mermaid	The mermaid, the siren divided	Ascent to the lamp; Promethean devouring

The third invariant runs beneath every row. Thomasin is separated by banishment and menarche, lives her liminal interval under her family's accusation, and is received by the coven. Winslow is separated from the mainland and from his name, lives his liminality on the rock, and is received by the light. Amleth is separated by his father's murder, lives his liminality as berserker and slave, and is received by Valhalla. Ellen is separated by her husband's departure, lives her liminality as the possessed, and is received by death in the vampire's embrace. In no case does reaggregation return the initiate to the community that separated her.

Read down its columns, the table discloses three regularities that no single film reveals. The anomalous mediators are predominantly carrion-feeders or sacrificial beasts. The threshold-sovereign is always feminine, and present even in the film without a woman. The terminal ecstasy is always vertical and always luminous or fiery. The sections that follow theorize each regularity in turn.

7.3 The Wolf's Head: Ban, Outlawry, and the Wargus

The second invariant gives the theory its name. Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) located the originary political relation not in contract or citizenship but in the ban: the sovereign's capacity to exclude a life from the protection of the law while leaving it exposed to the law's violence. Its archaic figure is the *homo sacer*, who may be killed but not sacrificed; its Germanic equivalent is the outlaw. The Frankish *Lex Salica* declared the grave-robber *wargus*, a wolf. The Anglo-Norman *Leges Edwardi Confessoris* (c. 1140) declared that from the day of his outlawry a man bears a wolf's head, *lupinum enim gerit caput a die utlagationis suae, quod ab Anglis wulfesheved nominatur*, and Bracton, in the thirteenth century, repeated that the outlaw *caput gerit lupinum*. Icelandic law named the full outlaw *skógarmaðr*, "forest-man," and his sentence *skóggangr*, "forest-going": the outlaw belonged to the woods, and anyone might kill him. The sagas made such men heroes: Grettir the Strong, who wrestled the revenant Glámr and was cursed with a lifelong terror of the dark; Gísli Súrsson; and, in mythic register, Sigmund and Sinfjötli in their wolf-skins.

Agamben concludes that the bandit's life is neither human nor animal but a werewolf's: a zone of indistinction between man and beast, nature and city, that the sovereign ban produces and holds within itself. Plautus had already written *lupus est homo homini* (*Asinaria* 495), and Hobbes made *homo homini lupus* the formula of the state of nature (*De Cive*, 1642). The wolf is what the city imagines it has left behind, and what its ban perpetually manufactures.

Every Eggers protagonist bears the wolf's head. William's household is sentenced to forest-going in the most literal sense, driven to the edge of the woods. Winslow lives under a dead man's name on a rock where his death would trouble no one. Amleth is exile, berserker, and slave in succession. Ellen is diagnosed, confined, and finally offered up, a life whose sacrifice the town accepts without having to decide it. Orlok, finally, is the banned dead, refused even by death. In each case the banned subject remains inside the law from which it is excluded. William's family keeps the covenant; Winslow's labor is entered in the logbook; Amleth keeps his vow; Ellen keeps her marriage. Inclusive exclusion is the shape of every Eggers plot.

7.4 The Anomalous Mediator: Carrion, Pack, Gaze

The predominance of carrion-feeders in Eggers's bestiary has a structural explanation. Claude Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) asked why the raven and the coyote serve as tricksters in North American mythology and answered that, as carrion-eaters, they occupy the position between herbivores and predators, eating flesh without killing, and so mediate between life and death. Eggers's ravens, gulls, and rats occupy exactly that position, and they cluster exactly where the living pass to the dead: the raven at the delirious mother's breast, the gulls at the body on the rocks, the rats at the plague pits. Mary Douglas (1966) showed that the anomalous animal, which violates the categories by which a culture orders the world, is ordinarily an abomination but may become a sacrament, as the pangolin did among the Lele of the Kasai. Black Phillip (domestic beast and devil), the mermaid (woman, fish, and bird), the berserker (man and wolf), and Orlok (living and dead, man and rat) are anomalies in Douglas's sense, abominable and sacred at once.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's A *Thousand Plateaus* (1980) supplies the dynamic dimension. In the plateau on becoming-animal, they argue that the sorcerer allies himself not with the pack but with the "anomal," the exceptional individual at its border, as Ahab with Moby-Dick, and that sorcerers have always dwelt at the edge of the village, between the fields and the woods. Among their examples is Daniel Mann's *Willard* (1971), in which a man's becoming-rat is mediated by a single rat. Thomasin's pact with Black Phillip is an alliance with the anomal of the herd; Amleth's berserker band is a pack, and his becoming-wolf its line of flight; Winslow's one-eyed gull is the anomal of the colony; Orlok, master of a pack of rats, is himself the anomal of the dead. Deleuze and Guattari conceived becoming-animal as a line of flight from the human; Eggers stages it as flight and capture at once.

Jacques Derrida's *The Animal That Therefore I Am* (2006) began from a scene: the philosopher, naked, seen by his cat, and ashamed of being ashamed. The animal's gaze precedes and exposes the human. Eggers's animals look back—Black Phillip's level stare, the gull's single eye, the raven, the fox—and at the climax of every film the human stands naked before them: Thomasin before the goat, Winslow before the gulls, Amleth at the gate of Hel, Ellen bared to the vampire. The terminal nakedness of every protagonist is the return to what Agamben called

bare life, *zoē* stripped of *bios*, under the gaze of the animal that conducts it across.

7.5 The Threshold-Sovereign: Toward an Ontological Decisionism

Schmitt's sovereign decides on the exception. The threshold-sovereign decides on the exception between orders of being: whether, when, and for whom the boundary between human and animal, living and dead, natural and supernatural is suspended. Ibn Faḍlān's slave girl, lifted above the door-frame, gives the type its archaic image: the woman sees over the threshold, and her body is the vehicle of passage. Across the corpus the function is constant while its bearers vary. Thomasin decides to sign. The witch and her coven receive. The mermaid calls. Gudrún decides who will be king. Olga offers the counter-fate and the Seeress foresees it. The Valkyrie chooses the slain. Ellen summons the vampire as a girl and, as a woman, admits and destroys him, in accordance with the oldest rule of the lore.

The concept is advanced against two readings. Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine (1993), the most influential feminist theory of the horror film, makes woman the abject object through which patriarchal culture figures its dread of the maternal body. It describes Katherine's trajectory and the iconography of the mermaid exactly, and it misses the decisive fact that in Eggers the feminine decides. The emancipatory reading that descends from Michelet and is renewed by Federici makes the witch a rebel against Church, lord, and capital. It captures Thomasin's flight, and it misses the fact that the threshold-sovereign's power is not liberation from the order but administration of its outside, and that this power is terrible. Clément's diptych of the sorceress and the hysteric, introduced in Chapter Five, comes closest: contestation and containment at once.

Mythography supplies further coordinates, to be handled with caution. Robert Graves's *The White Goddess* (1948), unreliable as history, is uncannily exact as a description of Eggers's structure, in which a goddess of threefold aspect chooses and destroys the sacred king: Gudrún chooses and destroys kings, Ellen destroys the Count, and the mermaid's call precedes the destruction of the keeper's successor. Steinsland's giantess-sovereignty and the Irish goddess of Sovereignty give the structure firmer scholarly ground. The deepest coordinate is philosophical. In the *Timaeus* (48e–52d), Plato introduced a "third kind"

between intelligible being and sensible becoming: the *chōra*, receptacle and nurse of becoming, neither being nor becoming, which Western thought gendered feminine from the outset and which Kristeva (1974) and Derrida (1993) both reworked. The threshold has been feminine since Plato. Eggers's threshold-sovereigns are the *chōra* endowed with a will.

7.6 Terminal Ecstasy: The Numinous as Consummation

Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the numinous as a *mysterium* at once *tremendum*—awful, overpowering, urgent—and *fascinans*, irresistibly attractive. Eggers's endings fuse the two beyond the possibility of separation. Their form is constant. Each is vertical: the levitation, the tower, the Valkyrie's flight, and, inverted, the sun rising upon Ellen's bed. Each is luminous or fiery: the sabbat fire, the lamp, the volcano, the dawn. Eliade's *Shamanism* (1951) identified ecstatic ascent along an *axis mundi*—tree, pole, ladder, mountain—as the defining technique of the shaman, and Eggers supplies an axis to every film: the forest, the lighthouse stair, the World Tree and the fire-mountain, the Carpathian heights from which the vampire descends.

Lacan's "between two deaths" names the interval that the terminal ecstasy closes. Each protagonist dies twice: once symbolically—Thomasin condemned by her family, Winslow living under a dead man's name, Amleth branded a slave, Ellen pronounced ill and offered—and once in fact or in apotheosis. Bataille's late theory of sovereignty, written in the 1950s and published posthumously in 1976, defines the sovereign moment as one that serves nothing: the miraculous instant, freed from utility, encountered in laughter, intoxication, eroticism, sacrifice, and death. Each ending is sovereign in this sense: useless, glorious, consuming. Its valence—apotheosis or damnation, deliverance or punishment—is undecidable, and the undecidability is not ambiguity but structure: the formal trace of the ban, in which the excluded life is at once accursed and sacred. Blake's marriage of heaven and hell is its proper name.

7.7 Ontological Re-Possession: The Spectator as Initiand

Victor Turner's *From Ritual to Theatre* (1982) distinguished the *liminal*—the obligatory, collective, sacred passages of tribal and agrarian societies—from the *liminoid*—the optional, individual, playful genres of industrial leisure, among them theatre, art, and cinema. Cinema is liminoid. Eggers's ambition is to make it function as liminal: to convert a leisure commodity into a rite of passage. The spectator undergoes separation (the darkened auditorium, the estranging speech) and liminality (ritual duration, the porous self), and, because the films displace reaggregation into the numinous, is returned to the world without being reaggregated. The unease these films notoriously leave behind is the residue of an initiation without return. This is ontological re-possession: the buffered self made temporarily porous, and released before its buffers are fully restored.

Robin Wood's model of the horror film as the return of the repressed presupposed that what returns belongs to the subject's own repressed. What returns in Eggers belongs neither to the individual unconscious nor, as Jung would have it, to an innate collective one. It belongs to a historical archive of ways of being in the world: covenant, *urðr*, contract, correspondence. The modern subject did not repress these ontologies; it descended from them and banned them. Hence the deepest formulation of the films' horror: *the modern subject is the outlaw of its own ancestral cosmos.* We bear the wolf's head in the world of our ancestors. Benjamin's second thesis spoke of a secret agreement between past generations and the present one, and of the weak messianic power on which the past has a claim. Eggers's films enforce that claim. They are the dead calling in a debt.

7.8 Two Misreadings and a Third Way

The structure invites two misreadings. The first is reactionary. Its genealogy runs through René Guénon's *The Reign of Quantity* (1945) and Julius Evola's *Revolt Against the Modern World* (1934), a fascist traditionalism that idealized sacral kingship, warrior castes, and "solar" virility. On this reading, Eggers's archaic worlds are objects of nostalgia and modernity their decline. The films refute it. Their archaic orders are never idealized; they are lethal. The sacral king is murdered by his brother, and his glory rests on rape; the covenant devours its children; the priest of the light is a tyrant; the feudal claim is a rotting corpse. Nothing in Eggers is restored. Everything is re-possessed, and possession is horror.

The second misreading is emancipatory: *The Witch* as a feminist liberation narrative, *The Northman* as a critique of toxic masculinity, *Nosferatu* as a parable of female desire against patriarchal medicine. Each captures a real vector and flattens it onto the axis of present-day values, recruiting the films as allegories of the present. The threshold-sovereign's power is not emancipation but the administration of a terrible threshold; the films' critique of masculinity is also its apotheosis; Ellen's desire saves the order that pathologized it.

The third way is hospitality to the dead. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) opens with Hamlet's "The time is out of joint" and insists that one must learn to live with ghosts, to speak with them, and to inherit from them without either worship or exorcism. His *Of Hospitality* (1997) distinguished an unconditional hospitality owed to whoever arrives from the conditional hospitality of laws, thresholds, and invitations. The vampire is the guest who requires an invitation, and Eggers's cinema is an extended experiment in conditional hospitality toward the dead. It summons them by archival invocation, admits them across the threshold of the screen, and must then decide what they may take. Its ethic is neither nostalgia nor critique but this risk: a *spectral ethnography* in which the past is received as a guest whose demands cannot be known in advance.

7.9 Prospective Coda: Werwulf and the Test of the Hypothesis

A theory that claims to describe an apparatus should be able to predict its next product. Eggers's fifth feature, *Werwulf*, is scheduled for release on 25 December 2026, and what is known of it comes from pre-release reporting. It is set in thirteenth-century England and co-written with Sjón; its dialogue is composed in Middle English with the help of two Oxford scholars; it was conceived in black and white and shot in color (World of Reel). Its cast includes Willem Dafoe and Ralph Ineson, with Aaron Taylor-Johnson and Lily-Rose Depp credited as "Man" and "Woman" (The Hollywood Reporter). Its studio promises a tale of "devotion, damnation and the devil within" (Focus Features), and Eggers has called it the darkest script he has written (Wikipedia).

If the hypothesis holds, the century is chosen with the same structural precision as the others. The Fourth Lateran Council of 1215 required every Christian to confess at least once a year (canon 21, *Omnis utriusque sexus*), the step Foucault (1976) identified as decisive in the production of the confessing subject; its canon 18 forbade clergy to bless the ordeal, and England abandoned the judicial ordeal by 1219 (Bartlett 1986). The judgment of God gave way to human inquiry and the jury: the law disenchanted itself. R. I. Moore (1987) dated to the years between 950 and 1250 the formation of a "persecuting society," in which Latin Christendom constructed its categories of exclusion: heretics, Jews, lepers, sodomites. The Charter of the Forest (1217) redrew the bounds of the royal forests, the juridical space of the outlaw whom the *Leges Edwardi Confessoris* and Bracton had declared a wolf's head. The thirteenth century is the threshold at which the law disenchanted itself and, in the same gesture, produced the wolf as its remainder.

Its literature of werewolves was rich. Marie de France's "Bisclavret" (c. 1170s) tells of a Breton baron who becomes a wolf each week and can resume human shape only by recovering his clothes; his wife has them stolen, trapping him in wolf-form, and he takes his revenge upon her face. Gerald of Wales's *Topographia Hibernica* (c. 1188) tells of a couple from Ossory condemned to live as wolves, and of a priest asked to give the viaticum to a dying she-wolf whose skin, peeled back, discloses an old woman. Gervase of Tilbury (c. 1211–14) reported that men in England were often seen to change into wolves with the phases of the moon. *Guillaume de Palerne* (c. 1200), later Englished as *William of Palerne*,

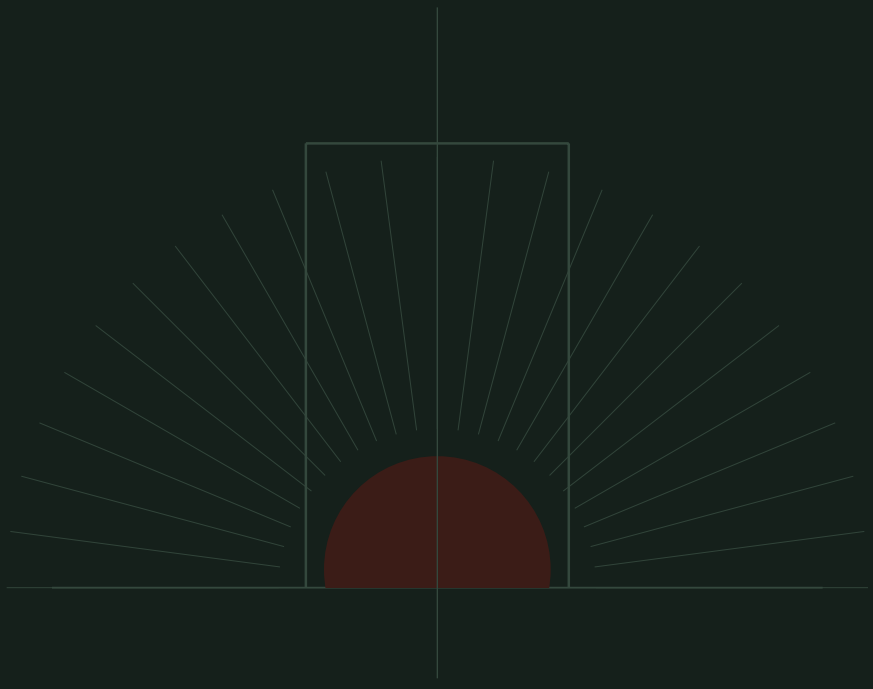
made a werewolf the hero's protector. Caroline Walker Bynum (2001) has shown that this fascination was a sustained medieval inquiry into identity and change, hybridity and metamorphosis.

On these grounds the lycanthropic hypothesis yields six predictions, offered in the spirit of falsification. (I) *Werwulf* will stage a threshold of disenchantment, most plausibly the juridical and penitential rationalization of thirteenth-century Church and Crown, against which the wolf appears as remainder. (II) Its protagonist will be a creature of the ban, the *wulfesheved*, in whom, for the first time in the corpus, the banned subject and the anomalous mediator coincide in a single body; early marketing, which describes Taylor-Johnson's character as a man haunted by a terrifying transformation, is consistent with this. (III) Its narrative will take the form of an initiation without return, whose liminal phase, the alternation between forms, recurs rather than resolves. (IV) Its mediator will be internalized: the wolf will dwell not beside the protagonist but within him, as the studio's "devil within" already intimates, in the century that made confession an annual obligation. (V) Its "Woman" will occupy the position of the threshold-sovereign, in the manner of Bisclavret's wife, who holds the garment on which the passage between forms depends: she who keeps the clothes keeps the threshold. (VI) Its consummation will be a terminal ecstasy by fire, light, or air, its valence undecidable between damnation and apotheosis.

The credit "Man" is itself a sign. The object of lycanthropology has become the protagonist's name: *anthrōpos* as the wolf. Should *Werwulf* resolve its wolf into a natural explanation—clinical *lycanthropia*, Todorov's uncanny—or reintegrate its protagonist into the social order, the hypothesis is weakened. Should its Woman prove merely victim or merely monster, the concept of the threshold-sovereign will require revision. The dissertation exposes itself to refutation on 25 December 2026.

Conclusion

The Hour of the Wolf



Ingmar Bergman's *Hour of the Wolf* (1968) opens with a title explaining that the hour of the wolf is the hour between night and dawn: the hour, according to the old belief it invokes, in which most people die and most are born, sleep is deepest, and nightmares are most real. On a remote island the painter Johan Borg is besieged by figures who may be demons, and his wife Alma, who has lived with him long enough to begin seeing what he sees, testifies at the film's close to his disappearance into the forest. It is an Eggers film *avant la lettre*: an island, a possession, a woman who sees across the threshold, a forest that takes. And it names the hour in which Eggers's rites are consummated. Each of his terminal ecstasies occurs at a boundary of darkness and light: the sabbat fire in the forest night, the lamp blazing in its lantern room, the fire-mountain at the gate of Hel, the dawn that breaks upon Ellen's bed. Cinema itself keeps that hour. The auditorium is darkened for a waking dream that ends when the lights return, and Eggers's films are built so that the spectator wakes changed.

This dissertation has argued that Eggers's corpus is a single project and has proposed *lycanthropology* as that project's name. Its contributions are of three kinds. The first is theoretical: eight concepts—hierophantic realism, in which archival fidelity serves as a prosthesis of faith; the threshold of disenchantment, with the counter-genealogy that the diegetic chronology composes; the ban; initiation without return; the anomalous mediator; the threshold-sovereign, the basis of an ontological decisionism; terminal ecstasy; and ontological re-possession—together with the subsidiary notions of epochal epistemology, transcendental horror, endogenous folk horror, and spectral ethnography. The second is interpretive: a set of readings that the theory makes possible and that, in turn, test it. Among them are the Devil's dispensation of the assurance Calvinism withheld and the scriptural cento of Black Phillip's temptation; *The Lighthouse* as Frazer's Nemi, the lighthouse as the island of Proteus, and the siren divided into mermaid and gull; Gudrún as the goddess of Sovereignty and the inverted inciter, read through Carol Clover's double expertise in horror and saga; Ellen as *strigoi viu* and 1838 as the photographic threshold; and Clément's sorceress and hysteric as the poles between which the corpus's feminine sovereignty moves. The third contribution is methodological: the braiding of source criticism, comparative mythology, psychoanalysis as a hermeneutic of structure, and formal analysis within Agamben's paradigmatic method, under the

discipline of an emic-etic distinction that the films themselves solicit.

The study's limitations are those of its object and its moment. The corpus is small—four completed features and a handful of short films, the latter treated only in passing—and claims about an apparatus drawn from four instances are inductive in a way that the paradigmatic method mitigates but cannot abolish. The interpretive method privileges structure over reception. An empirical study of audiences, asking how ontological re-possession is actually undergone and by whom, lies beyond its scope, as does a production history built from archival access to the research materials of Eggers and his collaborators. A wider comparative question also remains: whether the lycanthropic dispositif describes other contemporary cinemas of the sacred, or only this one. And the prospective coda stakes the theory on a film its author has not seen, which is as it should be. A theory of an apparatus that cannot be wrong about the apparatus's next product is not a theory but a description.

The idiom with which this dissertation began contains a warning that applies to the dissertation itself. To speak of the wolf is to summon it. A lycanthropology cannot remain outside its object, for to theorize the ban is to rehearse it, to name the excluded is to invite it in, and to describe a hospitality toward the dead is already to extend one. Eggers's films know this; it is their method. They speak of the witch, the keeper, the wolf-warrior, and the revenant in the idiom of the dead, and the dead come. In Terence's comedy, the slave Syrus, seeing the old man approach at the very moment his name is spoken, says only *lupus in fabula*. The phrase is not a lament but a recognition: that the past was never absent, only unnamed; that modernity's wolves were always at the edge of the clearing; and that a culture which has forgotten how to speak of them has not thereby ceased to summon them. It has only lost the words. Eggers has spent a career recovering them, and the hour of the wolf is the hour in which they are spoken.

Selected Bibliography

Filmography: Robert Eggers

Eggers, Robert, dir. *Hansel and Gretel*. Short film, 2007.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *The Tell-Tale Heart*. Short film, 2008.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *Brothers*. Short film, 2015.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *The Witch: A New-England Folktale*. Written by Robert Eggers. Premiered at the Sundance Film Festival, 2015; released by A24, 2016.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *The Lighthouse*. Written by Robert Eggers and Max Eggers. A24, 2019.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *The Northman*. Written by Sjón and Robert Eggers. Focus Features, 2022.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *Nosferatu*. Written by Robert Eggers. Focus Features, 2024.

Eggers, Robert, dir. *Werwulf*. Written by Robert Eggers and Sjón. Focus Features, scheduled for release 25 December 2026.

Other Films and Television Cited

Alfredson, Tomas. *Let the Right One In*, 2008. Argento, Dario. *Suspiria*, 1977. Aster, Ari. *Hereditary*, 2018; *Midsommar*, 2019. Bergman, Ingmar. *Persona*, 1966; *Hour of the Wolf* (*Vargtimmen*), 1968. Bruckner, David. *The Ritual*, 2017. Christensen, Benjamin. *Häxan*, 1922. Coppola, Francis Ford. *Bram Stoker's Dracula*, 1992. Dreyer, Carl Theodor. *Vampyr*, 1932; *Day of Wrath* (*Vredens dag*), 1943. Epstein, Jean. *Finis Terrae*, 1929. Evans, Gareth. *Apostle*, 2018. Feigelfeld, Lukas. *Hagazussa*, 2017. Fisher, Terence. *Dracula*, 1958. Gatiss, Mark. *A History of Horror*. BBC Four, 2010. German, Aleksei. *Hard to Be a God*, 2013. Glass, Rose. *Saint Maud*, 2019. Grémillon, Jean. *Gardiens de phare*, 1929. Guadagnino, Luca. *Suspiria*, 2018. Haggard, Piers. *The Blood on Satan's Claw*, 1971. Hardy, Robin. *The Wicker Man*, 1973. Herzog, Werner. *Nosferatu: Phantom der Nacht*, 1979. Jarmusch, Jim. *Only Lovers Left Alive*, 2013. Jóhannsson, Valdimar. *Lamb*, 2021. Klimov, Elem. *Come and See*, 1985. Kubrick, Stanley. *The Shining*, 1980. Kurosawa, Akira. *Throne of Blood*, 1957. Lowery, David. *The Green Knight*, 2021. Mann, Daniel. *Willard*, 1971. Merhige, E. Elias. *Shadow of the Vampire*, 2000. Milius, John. *Conan the Barbarian*, 1982. Murnau, F. W. *Nosferatu: eine Symphonie des Grauens*, 1922. Polanski, Roman. *Cul-de-sac*, 1966. Reeves, Michael. *Witchfinder General*, 1968. Refn, Nicolas Winding. *Valhalla Rising*, 2009. Romero, George A. *Martin*, 1977. Russell, Ken. *The Devils*, 1971. Scorsese, Martin. *The Last Temptation of Christ*, 1988. Shindō, Kaneto. *Onibaba*, 1964; *Kuroneko*, 1968. Stolevski, Goran. *You Won't Be Alone*, 2022. Tarkovsky, Andrei. *Andrei Rublev*, 1966. Vláčil, František. *Marketa Lazarová*, 1967. Wheatley, Ben. *Kill List*, 2011. Zemeckis, Robert. *Beowulf*, 2007.

Primary Sources: Ancient, Medieval, and Early Modern

Aeschylus (attributed). *Prometheus Bound.*

Aristotle. *Poetics.*

Ars Goetia. In *The Lesser Key of Solomon.* Seventeenth century.

Bacon, Francis. *Sylva Sylvarum.* London, 1627.

Belleforest, François de. *Histoires tragiques.* Vol. 5. Paris, 1570.

The Holy Bible (Authorized Version). London, 1611.

Bracton, Henry de (attributed). *De legibus et consuetudinibus Angliae.* Thirteenth century.

Bradford, William. *Of Plymouth Plantation.* Written 1630–51.

Burton, Robert. *The Anatomy of Melancholy.* Oxford, 1621.

Caesar, Julius. *De Bello Gallico.*

Calvin, John. *Institutio Christianae religionis.* Geneva, 1559.

Carta de Foresta (Charter of the Forest). 1217.

Crist I (*The Advent Lyrics*). In the Exeter Book. Tenth century.

Della Porta, Giambattista. *Magiae naturalis.* Naples, 1558.

Echtra mac nEchach Muigmedóin. Middle Irish.

Egils saga Skalla-Grímssonar.

Eiríks saga rauða.

Fourth Lateran Council. *Constitutiones.* 1215.

Gerald of Wales. *Topographia Hibernica.* c. 1188.

Gervase of Tilbury. *Otia imperialia.* c. 1211–14.

Gísla saga Súrssonar.

Gowdie, Isobel. Confessions. Auldearn, 1662.

Grettis saga Ásmundarsonar.

Guillaume de Palerne. c. 1200.

Hesiod. *Theogony.*

Hobbes, Thomas. *De Cive.* Paris, 1642.

Holinshed, Raphael. *The Chronicles of England, Scotland, and Irelande.* London, 1577.

Homer. *Odyssey.*

Hopkins, Matthew. *The Discovery of Witches.* London, 1647.

Ibn Faḍlān, Aḥmad. *Risāla.* c. 922.

Kalevala. Compiled by Elias Lönnrot. 1835; enlarged ed., 1849.

Laxdæla saga.

Leges Edwardi Confessoris. c. 1140.

Lévi, Éliphas. *Dogme et rituel de la haute magie*. Paris, 1854–56.

Lex Salica.

Liber monstrorum. c. eighth century.

Marie de France. "Bisclavret." c. 1170s.

Mather, Cotton. *Memorable Providences, Relating to Witchcrafts and Possessions*. Boston, 1689.

Mather, Cotton. *The Wonders of the Invisible World*. Boston, 1693.

Mather, Increase. *An Essay for the Recording of Illustrious Providences*. Boston, 1684.

The Most Strange and Admirable Discoverie of the Three Witches of Warboys. London, 1593.

Njáls saga.

Paul of Aegina. *Epitome of Medicine*. Seventh century.

Perkins, William. *A Case of Conscience, the Greatest That Ever Was*. 1592.

Plato. *Timaeus*.

Plautus. *Asinaria*.

Pliny the Elder. *Naturalis historia*.

Plutarch. *De defectu oraculorum*.

Poetic Edda: *Völuspá*, *Hávamál*, *Grímnismál*, *Lokasenna*, *Skírnismál*.

Salem Village witchcraft examinations, including the examination of Tituba. 1692.

Saxo Grammaticus. *Gesta Danorum*. c. 1200.

Shakespeare, William. *Hamlet*. c. 1600.

Shakespeare, William. *Macbeth*. c. 1606.

Snorri Sturluson. *Edda* (*Gylfaginning*, *Skáldskaparmál*). c. 1220.

Snorri Sturluson. *Heimskringla* (*Ynglinga saga*). c. 1230.

Terence. *Adelphoe*. 160 BC.

Þjóðólfr of Hvinir. *Ynglingatal*.

Þorbjörn hornklofi. *Haraldskvæði* (*Hrafnsmál*). c. 900.

Virgil. *Eclogues*; *Georgics*.

Völsunga saga. Thirteenth century.

Wigglesworth, Michael. *The Day of Doom*. Cambridge, MA, 1662.

Winthrop, John. *A Modell of Christian Charity*. 1630.

Winthrop, John. *A Short Story of the Rise, Reign, and Ruine of the Antinomians, Familists & Libertines*. London, 1644.

Literary and Musical Sources, 1790–2015

Beckett, Samuel. *En attendant Godot*. Paris: Minuit, 1952; first performed 1953.

Beckett, Samuel. *Fin de partie*. Paris: Minuit, 1957.

Blackwood, Algernon. "The Willows." 1907.

Blackwood, Algernon. "The Wendigo." 1910.

Blake, William. *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*. c. 1790.

Bulwer-Lytton, Edward. *Zanoni*. London, 1842.

Carter, Angela. *The Bloody Chamber*. London: Gollancz, 1979.

Coleridge, Samuel Taylor. "The Rime of the Ancyent Marinere." In *Lyrical Ballads*. London, 1798.

Gardner, John. *Grendel*. New York: Knopf, 1971.

Gerard, Emily. "Transylvanian Superstitions." *The Nineteenth Century* 18 (1885).

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. "Prometheus." 1774.

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. "Die Braut von Korinth." 1797.

Grimm, Jacob, and Wilhelm Grimm. *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*. Vol. 1. Berlin, 1812.

Hawthorne, Nathaniel. "Young Goodman Brown." 1835.

Hoffmann, E. T. A. "Der Sandmann." 1816.

Huxley, Aldous. *The Devils of Loudun*. London: Chatto & Windus, 1952.

James, M. R. "Oh, Whistle, and I'll Come to You, My Lad." In *Ghost Stories of an Antiquary*. London, 1904.

Jewett, Sarah Orne. *The Country of the Pointed Firs*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1896.

Kerner, Justinus. *Die Seherin von Prevorst*. Stuttgart, 1829.

Le Fanu, J. Sheridan. *Carmilla*. In *In a Glass Darkly*. London, 1872.

Lovecraft, H. P. "Supernatural Horror in Literature." *The Recluse*, 1927.

Lovecraft, H. P. *The Shadow over Innsmouth*. 1936.

Macaulay, Thomas Babington. *Lays of Ancient Rome*. London, 1842.

Machen, Arthur. *The Great God Pan*. London: John Lane, 1894.

Machen, Arthur. "The White People." 1904.

McCarthy, Cormac. *Blood Meridian*. New York: Random House, 1985.

Melville, Herman. *Moby-Dick*. New York: Harper, 1851.

Miller, Arthur. *The Crucible*. New York: Viking, 1953.

Milton, John. *Paradise Lost*. London, 1667.

Nerval, Gérard de. "El Desdichado." In *Les Chimères*. 1854.

Novalis. *Hymnen an die Nacht*. 1800.

Poe, Edgar Allan. "William Wilson." 1839.

Poe, Edgar Allan. “The Premature Burial.” 1844.

Poe, Edgar Allan. “The Light-House.” Unfinished, 1849.

Polidori, John. *The Vampyre*. London, 1819.

Rice, Anne. *Interview with the Vampire*. New York: Knopf, 1976.

Rilke, Rainer Maria. *Duineser Elegien*. Leipzig: Insel, 1923.

Shelley, Mary. *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. London, 1818.

Shelley, Percy Bysshe. *Prometheus Unbound*. London, 1820.

Sjón. *Skugga-Baldur*. Reykjavík: Bjartur, 2003.

Stoker, Bram. *Dracula*. London: Constable, 1897.

Tolkien, J. R. R. *The Story of Kullervo*. Edited by Verlyn Flieger. London: HarperCollins, 2015.

Wagner, Richard. *Tristan und Isolde*. First performed Munich, 1865.

Wagner, Richard. *Götterdämmerung*. First performed Bayreuth, 1876.

Theory, Criticism, and Scholarship

Agamben, Giorgio. *Homo sacer: Il potere sovrano e la nuda vita*. Turin: Einaudi, 1995.

Agamben, Giorgio. *L’aperto: L’uomo e l’animale*. Turin: Bollati Boringhieri, 2002.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Stato di eccezione*. Turin: Bollati Boringhieri, 2003.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Che cos’è un dispositivo?* Rome: Nottetempo, 2006.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Il sacramento del linguaggio: Archeologia del giuramento*. Rome and Bari: Laterza, 2008.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Signatura rerum: Sul metodo*. Turin: Bollati Boringhieri, 2008.

Agrippa, Heinrich Cornelius. *De occulta philosophia libri tres*. Cologne, 1533.

Artaud, Antonin. “Le Théâtre et la peste” (1933). In *Le Théâtre et son double*. Paris: Gallimard, 1938.

Auerbach, Nina. *Our Vampires, Ourselves*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1995.

Austin, J. L. *How to Do Things with Words*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1962.

Bakhtin, Mikhail. *Rabelais and His World*. Translated by Hélène Iswolsky. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1968.

Barber, Paul. *Vampires, Burial, and Death: Folklore and Reality*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1988.

Bartlett, Robert. *Trial by Fire and Water: The Medieval Judicial Ordeal*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1986.

Bataille, Georges. “Soleil pourri.” *Documents* 3 (1930).

Bataille, Georges. *L’Anus solaire*. Paris: Galerie Simon, 1931.

Bataille, Georges. *La Part maudite*. Paris: Minuit, 1949.

Bataille, Georges. *L’Érotisme*. Paris: Minuit, 1957.

Bataille, Georges. *La Souveraineté*. In *Œuvres complètes*, vol. 8. Paris: Gallimard, 1976.

Bazin, André. "Ontologie de l'image photographique" (1945). In *Qu'est-ce que le cinéma?*, vol. 1. Paris: Cerf, 1958.

Benjamin, Walter. "Über den Begriff der Geschichte." Written 1940; first published 1942.

Bettelheim, Bruno. *The Uses of Enchantment*. New York: Knopf, 1976.

Blumenberg, Hans. *Arbeit am Mythos*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1979.

Boureau, Alain. *Le Droit de cuissage: La fabrication d'un mythe*. Paris: Albin Michel, 1995.

Breuer, Josef, and Sigmund Freud. *Studien über Hysterie*. Leipzig and Vienna: Deuticke, 1895.

Burkert, Walter. *Homo Necans*. Berlin: de Gruyter, 1972.

Bynum, Caroline Walker. *Metamorphosis and Identity*. New York: Zone Books, 2001.

Caporael, Linnda R. "Ergotism: The Satan Loosed in Salem?" *Science* 192, no. 4234 (1976): 21–26.

Carpentier, Alejo. Prologue to *El reino de este mundo*. Mexico City: EDIAPSA, 1949.

Carroll, Noël. *The Philosophy of Horror, or Paradoxes of the Heart*. New York: Routledge, 1990.

Church, David. *Post-Horror: Art, Genre, and Cultural Elevation*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2021.

Cixous, Hélène. "Le Rire de la Méduse." *L'Arc* 61 (1975).

Cixous, Hélène, and Catherine Clément. *La Jeune Née*. Paris: Union Générale d'Éditions, 1975.

Clark, Stuart. *Thinking with Demons: The Idea of Witchcraft in Early Modern Europe*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997.

Clover, Carol J. "Hildigunnr's Lament." In *Structure and Meaning in Old Norse Literature*, edited by John Lindow, Lars Lönnroth, and Gerd Wolfgang Weber. Odense: Odense University Press, 1986.

Clover, Carol J. *Men, Women, and Chain Saws: Gender in the Modern Horror Film*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1992.

Clover, Carol J. "Regardless of Sex: Men, Women, and Power in Early Northern Europe." *Speculum* 68, no. 2 (1993): 363–87.

Creed, Barbara. *The Monstrous-Feminine: Film, Feminism, Psychoanalysis*. London: Routledge, 1993.

Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. *Mille plateaux*. Paris: Minuit, 1980.

Derrida, Jacques. "Signature événement contexte." In *Marges de la philosophie*. Paris: Minuit, 1972.

Derrida, Jacques. *Spectres de Marx*. Paris: Galilée, 1993.

Derrida, Jacques. *Khôra*. Paris: Galilée, 1993.

Derrida, Jacques, and Anne Dufourmantelle. *De l'hospitalité*. Paris: Calmann-Lévy, 1997.

Derrida, Jacques. *L'Animal que donc je suis*. Paris: Galilée, 2006.

Descola, Philippe. *Par-delà nature et culture*. Paris: Gallimard, 2005.

Douglas, Mary. *Purity and Danger*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1966.

Dumézil, Georges. *Les Dieux des Germains*. Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1959.

Eisner, Lotte H. *L'Écran démoniaque*. Paris, 1952.

Ekirch, A. Roger. *At Day's Close: Night in Times Past*. New York: W. W. Norton, 2005.

Eliade, Mircea. *Le Chamanisme et les techniques archaïques de l'extase*. Paris: Payot, 1951.

Eliade, Mircea. *Das Heilige und das Profane*. Hamburg: Rowohlt, 1957.

Eliade, Mircea. *Birth and Rebirth: The Religious Meanings of Initiation in Human Culture*. New York: Harper, 1958.

Evola, Julius. *Rivolta contro il mondo moderno*. Milan: Hoepli, 1934.

Federici, Silvia. *Caliban and the Witch*. Brooklyn: Autonomedia, 2004.

Fisher, Mark. *The Weird and the Eerie*. London: Repeater, 2016.

Florensky, Pavel. *Iconostasis*. Written 1922.

Foucault, Michel. "Nietzsche, la généalogie, l'histoire." In *Hommage à Jean Hyppolite*. Paris: PUF, 1971.

Foucault, Michel. *La Volonté de savoir*. Paris: Gallimard, 1976.

Frazer, James George. *The Golden Bough*. London: Macmillan, 1890; 3rd ed., 1906–15.

Freud, Sigmund. *Totem und Tabu*. Leipzig and Vienna: Heller, 1913.

Freud, Sigmund. "Trauer und Melancholie." 1917.

Freud, Sigmund. "Das Unheimliche." *Imago* 5 (1919).

Freud, Sigmund. *Jenseits des Lustprinzips*. Vienna: Internationaler Psychoanalytischer Verlag, 1920.

Gaskill, Malcolm. *The Ruin of All Witches*. London: Allen Lane, 2021.

Genette, Gérard. *Seuils*. Paris: Seuil, 1987.

Ginzburg, Carlo. *Storia notturna: Una decifrazione del sabba*. Turin: Einaudi, 1989.

Girard, René. *La Violence et le sacré*. Paris: Grasset, 1972.

Girard, René. "The Plague in Literature and Myth." *Texas Studies in Literature and Language* 15, no. 5 (1974).

Girard, René. *A Theater of Envy: William Shakespeare*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1991.

Graves, Robert. *The White Goddess*. London: Faber and Faber, 1948.

Greenblatt, Stephen. *Hamlet in Purgatory*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2001.

Guénon, René. *Le Règne de la quantité et les signes des temps*. Paris: Gallimard, 1945.

Hegel, G. W. F. *Phänomenologie des Geistes*. Bamberg and Würzburg: Goebhardt, 1807.

Heidegger, Martin. "Der Ursprung des Kunstwerkes" (1935–36). In *Holzwege*. Frankfurt am Main: Klostermann, 1950.

Heidegger, Martin. "Die Frage nach der Technik." In *Vorträge und Aufsätze*. Pfullingen: Neske, 1954.

Heidegger, Martin. "Das Ende der Philosophie und die Aufgabe des Denkens" (1964). In *Zur Sache des Denkens*. Tübingen: Niemeyer, 1969.

Höfler, Otto. *Kultische Geheimbünde der Germanen*. Frankfurt am Main: Diesterweg, 1934.

Holbraad, Martin, and Morten Axel Pedersen. *The Ontological Turn: An Anthropological Exposition*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017.

Horkheimer, Max, and Theodor W. Adorno. *Dialektik der Aufklärung*. Amsterdam: Querido, 1947.

Hutton, Ronald. *The Witch: A History of Fear, from Ancient Times to the Present*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2017.

Josephson-Storm, Jason Ā. *The Myth of Disenchantment: Magic, Modernity, and the Birth of the Human Sciences*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2017.

Jung, C. G. "Über die Archetypen des kollektiven Unbewussten." *Eranos-Jahrbuch*, 1934.

Kantorowicz, Ernst H. *The King's Two Bodies: A Study in Mediaeval Political Theology*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957.

Karlsen, Carol F. *The Devil in the Shape of a Woman: Witchcraft in Colonial New England*. New York: W. W. Norton, 1987.

Kershaw, Kris. *The One-Eyed God: Odin and the (Indo-)Germanic Männerbünde*. Journal of Indo-European Studies Monograph 36. Washington, DC, 2000.

Kojève, Alexandre. *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*. Paris: Gallimard, 1947.

Kracauer, Siegfried. *From Caligari to Hitler*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1947.

Kristeva, Julia. *La Révolution du langage poétique*. Paris: Seuil, 1974.

Kristeva, Julia. *Pouvoirs de l'horreur*. Paris: Seuil, 1980.

Kristeva, Julia. *Soleil noir: Dépression et mélancolie*. Paris: Gallimard, 1987.

Lacan, Jacques. *Le Séminaire, livre VI: Le désir et son interprétation* (1958–59). Paris: La Martinière, 2013.

Lacan, Jacques. *Le Séminaire, livre VII: L'éthique de la psychanalyse* (1959–60). Paris: Seuil, 1986.

Latour, Bruno. *Nous n'avons jamais été modernes*. Paris: La Découverte, 1991.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. "The Structural Study of Myth." *Journal of American Folklore* 68, no. 270 (1955): 428–44.

Marx, Karl. *Das Kapital*. Vol. 1. Hamburg: Meissner, 1867. English translation by Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling, 1887.

Mesmer, Franz Anton. *Mémoire sur la découverte du magnétisme animal*. Paris, 1779.

Michelet, Jules. *La Sorcière*. Paris, 1862.

Miller, Perry. *Errand into the Wilderness*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1956.

Moore, R. I. *The Formation of a Persecuting Society*. Oxford: Blackwell, 1987.

Moretti, Franco. "The Dialectic of Fear." *New Left Review* 136 (1982).

Morgan, Edmund S. *The Puritan Family*. Boston: Trustees of the Public Library, 1944.

Morgan, Edmund S. *Visible Saints: The History of a Puritan Idea*. New York: New York University Press, 1963.

Murgoci, Agnes. "The Vampire in Roumania." *Folklore* 37, no. 4 (1926).

Murray, Margaret A. *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1921.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Die Geburt der Tragödie*. Leipzig: Fritzsch, 1872.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*. Chemnitz: Schmeitzner, 1882.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Zur Genealogie der Moral*. Leipzig: Naumann, 1887.

Otto, Rudolf. *Das Heilige*. Breslau: Trewendt & Granier, 1917.

Patterson, Orlando. *Slavery and Social Death*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982.

Pike, Kenneth L. *Language in Relation to a Unified Theory of the Structure of Human Behavior*. Glendale, CA: Summer Institute of Linguistics, 1954.

Price, Neil. *The Viking Way: Religion and War in Late Iron Age Scandinavia*. Uppsala, 2002; 2nd ed., Oxford: Oxbow, 2019.

Propp, Vladimir. *Morfologiya skazki*. Leningrad: Academia, 1928.

Rank, Otto. "Der Doppelgänger." *Imago* 3 (1914).

Ranke, Leopold von. *Geschichten der romanischen und germanischen Völker von 1494 bis 1514*. Leipzig and Berlin: Reimer, 1824.

Roh, Franz. *Nach-Expressionismus: Magischer Realismus*. Leipzig: Klinkhardt & Biermann, 1925.

Roper, Lyndal. *Oedipus and the Devil*. London: Routledge, 1994.

Roper, Lyndal. *Witch Craze: Terror and Fantasy in Baroque Germany*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2004.

Schelling, F. W. J. *Philosophie der Mythologie*. Published posthumously in *Sämmtliche Werke*, 1856–57.

Schivelbusch, Wolfgang. *Lichtblicke: Zur Geschichte der künstlichen Helligkeit im 19. Jahrhundert*. Munich: Hanser, 1983. Translated as *Disenchanted Night*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988.

Schmitt, Carl. *Politische Theologie*. Munich and Leipzig: Duncker & Humblot, 1922.

Schrader, Paul. *Transcendental Style in Film: Ozu, Bresson, Dreyer*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1972; rev. ed., 2018.

Schubert, Gotthilf Heinrich von. *Ansichten von der Nachtseite der Naturwissenschaft*. Dresden, 1808.

Scovell, Adam. *Folk Horror: Hours Dreadful and Things Strange*. Leighton Buzzard: Auteur, 2017.

Speidel, Michael P. "Berserks: A History of Indo-European 'Mad Warriors.'" *Journal of World History* 13, no. 2 (2002): 253–90.

Steinsland, Gro. *Det hellige bryllup og norrøn kongeideologi*. Oslo: Solum, 1991.

Summers, Montague. *The Vampire: His Kith and Kin*. London: Kegan Paul, 1928.

Tarkovsky, Andrei. *Sculpting in Time*. Translated by Kitty Hunter-Blair. London: Bodley Head, 1986.

Taylor, Charles. *A Secular Age*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2007.

Thacker, Eugene. *In the Dust of This Planet*. Winchester: Zero Books, 2011.

Thomas, Keith. *Religion and the Decline of Magic*. London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1971.

Todorov, Tzvetan. *Introduction à la littérature fantastique*. Paris: Seuil, 1970.

Tolkien, J. R. R. "Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics." *Proceedings of the British Academy* 22 (1936): 245–95.

Turner, Frederick Jackson. "The Significance of the Frontier in American History." 1893.

Turner, Victor. "Betwixt and Between: The Liminal Period in *Rites de Passage*." In *The Forest of Symbols*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1967.

Turner, Victor. *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure*. Chicago: Aldine, 1969.

Turner, Victor. *From Ritual to Theatre: The Human Seriousness of Play*. New York: PAJ Publications, 1982.

van Gennep, Arnold. *Les Rites de passage*. Paris: Nourry, 1909.

Viveiros de Castro, Eduardo. "Cosmological Deixis and Amerindian Perspectivism." *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 4, no. 3 (1998): 469–88.

von Franz, Marie-Louise. *The Problem of the Puer Aeternus*. Zürich: Spring Publications, 1970.

Warner, Marina. *From the Beast to the Blonde: On Fairy Tales and Their Tellers*. London: Chatto & Windus, 1994.

Warner, Marina. *No Go the Bogeyman: Scaring, Lulling and Making Mock*. London: Chatto & Windus, 1998.

Weber, Max. "Die protestantische Ethik und der 'Geist' des Kapitalismus." *Archiv für Sozialwissenschaft und Sozialpolitik* 20–21 (1904–05).

Weber, Max. *Wissenschaft als Beruf*. Munich: Duncker & Humblot, 1919.

Wimsatt, W. K., and Monroe C. Beardsley. "The Intentional Fallacy." *Sewanee Review* 54, no. 3 (1946): 468–88.

Wood, Robin. “An Introduction to the American Horror Film.” In *American Nightmare: Essays on the Horror Film*, edited by Robin Wood and Richard Lippe. Toronto: Festival of Festivals, 1979.

Online Sources Consulted (accessed 4 October 2026)

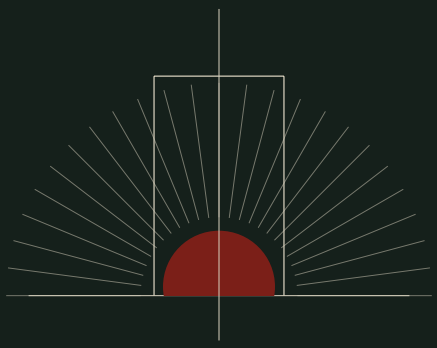
Kit, Borys. “Robert Eggers Reteams with Focus Features for 13th Century Werewolf Thriller ‘Werwulf’.” *The Hollywood Reporter*, 22 January 2025.

Focus Features. “Werwulf.” Official film page.

“Robert Eggers’ ‘Werwulf’ Gets First Official Trailer, and It’s Pure Eggers.” *World of Reel*, September 2026.

“Robert Eggers.” *Wikipedia*.

“Werwulf.” *Wikipedia*.



Keywords

Robert Eggers; lycanthropology; hierophantic realism; threshold of disenchantment; *Entzauberung*; re-enchantment; folk horror; endogenous folk horror; post-horror; ontological turn; ontological re-possession; porous and buffered self; epochal epistemology; transcendental horror; the ban; *homo sacer*; *wargus*; outlawry; wolf's head (*caput lupinum*); rites of passage; liminality; liminoid; initiation without return; anomalous mediator; becoming-animal; threshold-sovereign; ontological decisionism; *chōra*; terminal ecstasy; the numinous; *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*; sovereignty (Bataille); between two deaths; monstrous-feminine; sorceress and hysteric; Calvinism; predestination; covenant theology; Puritan New England; early modern witchcraft; demonology; witches' sabbath; folktale morphology; Frazer; Nemi; sacral kingship; the King's Two Bodies; Sovereignty goddess; lordship and bondage; *Dialectic of Enlightenment*; commodity fetishism; Prometheus; Proteus; sirens; Old Norse literature; Saxo Grammaticus; Amleth; *Hamlet*; fate (*urðr*, *wyrd*); *Männerbund*; berserkers; *seiðr*; mimetic desire; monstrous double; vampire; *Nosferatu*; Murnau; Romantic medicine; animal magnetism; *strigoi*; plague; state of exception; erotism; *Liebestod*; the fantastic; marvelous real; hauntology; spectral ethnography; werewolf; *Werwulf*; Fourth Lateran Council; persecuting society; Agamben; Bataille; Girard; Eliade; Benjamin; Weber; Lacan; Kristeva; Descola.